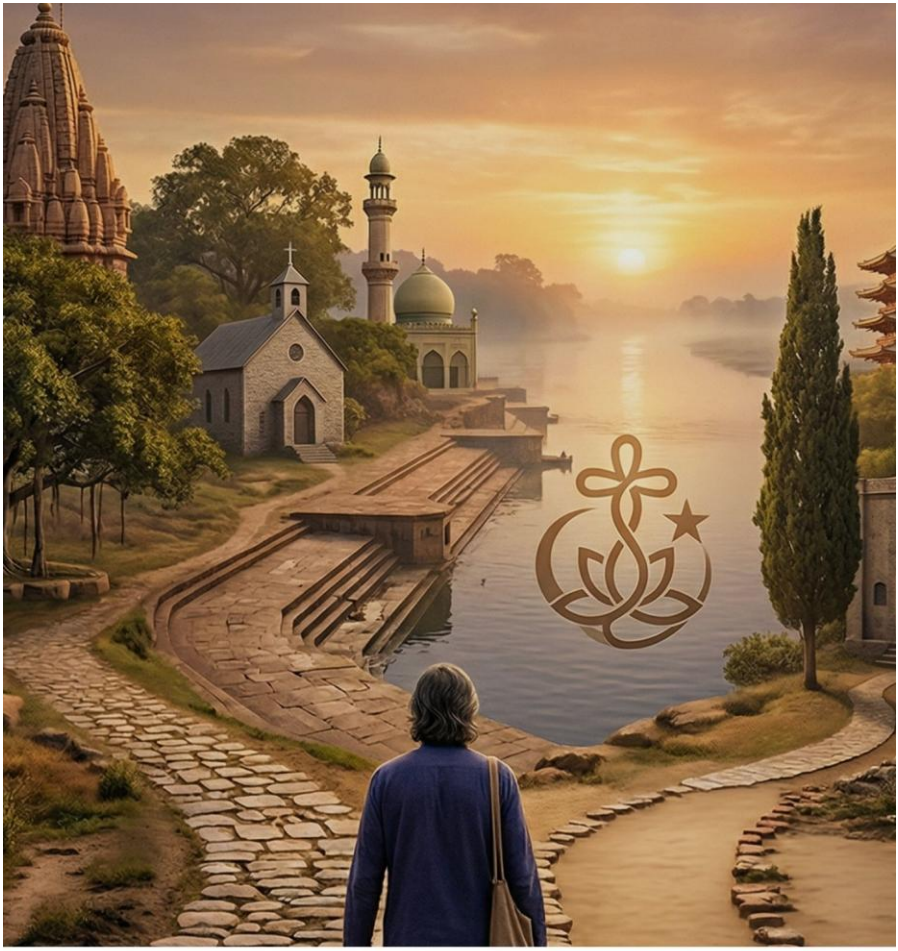

# SO MANY WAYS, SO MANY PATHS

*A Ramakrishna Experiment in Faith*

JOY BOSE

# So Many Paths, So Many Ways

## A Ramakrishna Experiment in Faith

**Joy Bose**

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*As Many Paths, So Many Ways*

A Ramakrishna Experiment in Faiths

# Introduction

## *The Experiment*

> *The tank has several ghats. Hindus drink water at one ghat, Muslims at another, Christians at yet another. All drink the same water. So, too, the Lord has made different religions suited to different times, countries and people. People feel that their own religion alone is true, others' are false, but actually all are right, all lead to the same place.*

— *Sri Ramakrishna Paramhamsa, as recorded in the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna*

### I. The Bookshop

There is a bookshop inside the Ramakrishna Mission campus in Lucknow, in the older part of the city, that smells of sandalwood and old paper and something else I have never been able to name. I have been going there since I was a child. The monk behind the counter will hand you a monthly journal called *Prabuddha Bharata*, which Swami Vivekananda started in 1896, and whose editorial panel still consists of professors and

learned people; he will not rush you. The books are priced around fifty rupees. You can spend a long time.

When I visited as an adult, on a return to Lucknow in the winter of 2007, I picked up a slim volume on the history and ideals of the Ramakrishna Math and Mission. Standing there in the cool garden light filtering through the leaves (the Mission has immaculate grounds, a strict no-photography rule inside the shrine room, straw mats for meditation) I read a sentence that I have been thinking about ever since.

Among the Mission's stated ideals, alongside god-realisation, the synthesis of the four yogas, and the philosophy of work as worship, was this: *harmony of religions both within Hinduism and world religions, as Ramakrishna verified.*

As Ramakrishna verified. Not as Ramakrishna preached, or believed, or hoped. As he *verified*. The language is empirical. He had run the experiment. He had the results.

I bought the book, put it in my bag, and walked back through the gardens past the shrine, where the triple images of Ramakrishna, Sarada Devi and Vivekananda watched the morning in silence. I did not yet know that I was about to spend the next several years running the same experiment myself.

## II. The Experimenter

Sri Ramakrishna Paramhamsa was born in 1836 in the Bengali village of Kamarpukur, into a poor Brahmin family, and died in 1886 of throat cancer in Calcutta. He spent most of his adult life as a priest at the Dakshineswar Kali temple on the banks of the Ganges, north of Calcutta, weeping before the goddess with such longing for the divine that he would fall into states of absorbed ecstasy, samadhi, so deep that he would forget to eat, forget where he was, sometimes appear, to those watching, to have briefly left his body behind.

He was not a scholar. He could not read Sanskrit easily. He had no interest in theological disputation for its own sake. What he had, instead, was an overwhelming experiential hunger: he wanted to *know* God the way you know your mother's face, immediately and without intermediary. He wanted to feel the reality that the scriptures pointed at, not merely study the fingers that pointed.

And so he practiced. He followed the Tantric path with a female guru named Bhairavi Brahmani. He practiced Vaishnava devotional disciplines, taking on the mood of Radha in her longing for Krishna. He followed the Advaita Vedanta path of non-dual enquiry under a wandering monk named Tota Puri, eventually reaching the state of nirvikalpa samadhi (the formless absorption that Advaita considers the summit of realisation) in a single day, where Tota Puri had taken forty years.

Then he turned to other traditions entirely. He practiced Islam, praying with Muslim teachers, eating food prepared in the Muslim way, repeating the name of Allah. He wore a cloth in the style of Muslims. He thought of Mohammed. And he reported, at the end of this period of practice, the same luminous presence he had encountered through Kali, through Krishna, through the formless Brahman.

Then Christianity. He meditated on the figure of Christ, read the Bible, sat with Christian devotees. And, according to his disciple Mahendranath Gupta, who recorded his conversations in the book known in English as *The Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna*, Ramakrishna had a vision of a luminous figure, radiant and compassionate, who merged into him.

From all of these he drew the same conclusion: that the divine is inexhaustible and equally accessible through every door that opens onto it with sufficient sincerity. That the paths are genuinely different (in practice, in texture, in emotional quality, in the kind of person they shape) but that the destination they share is real. He expressed this in a Bengali phrase that may be the most quietly radical statement in the history of comparative religion:

> *যত মত, তত পথ/ Joto mot, toto path. As many opinions, so many paths.*

Or, more freely: whatever way you face, if you face it with full honesty and full longing, you are facing God.

## III. The Question

I want to be honest about what kind of book this is, and what it is not.

It is not a work of academic theology or comparative religion. I am not a scholar of any of the faiths described in these pages. I have not read all the texts. I cannot adjudicate between competing interpretations of Sufi metaphysics or the finer distinctions between Vaishnavism and Shaivism. There are people who have spent lifetimes on each of the traditions I will be describing in the space of a chapter, and this book will inevitably seem, to them, a rushed tourist's account of their homeland.

What I am is something more like a witness. And what I witnessed (over roughly a decade, in Manchester and Bangalore and Lucknow and Delhi, in living rooms and prayer halls and retreat centres and open fields) was what it actually *felt like* to walk these paths in the body of a Bengali man in his late twenties and early thirties, with a software job and a persistent itch in the spirit that could not be scratched by any single tradition.

I grew up Hindu, though not in the ambient, non-doctrinal way that phrase sometimes implies. The household I grew up in had

a shape to it. My father visited the local Kali temple most mornings, and on Saturdays the same temple held a Shani Puja which was part of the regular rhythm of the week. My mother led the Lakshmi Puja at home on Thursday evenings, preparing the offerings herself, decorating the floor with alpana, blowing the conch shell, distributing the prasad. Both parents, each in their own way, maintained a daily practice: worship after the morning bath, water offered to Shiva, readings from the Bhagavad Gita, Sandhya at dusk. This was not performed for occasion or for guests. It was simply what the day contained.

The annual pilgrimage to Haridwar was another such given. My parents made it most years, as Bengali families have done for generations, to collect Ganga water for home worship and to stand at the ghats for the evening arati. On visits home from Manchester I joined them, and it was on one of those trips, watching the lamps float out from Har Ki Pauri on the current while priests chanted from three directions at once, that I understood something about what a living tradition actually looks like from the inside: not a set of beliefs held, but a set of practices maintained, year after year, regardless of whether any particular year felt especially meaningful.

Ramakrishna was a household name. Vivekananda was a hero. The idea that all religions lead to the same destination was something I had heard so many times it had become invisible, like a window I had stopped noticing because I never questioned

whether the view through it was accurate. What I had not done, growing up inside all of this, was arrive at the question myself. The experiment, when it came, came independently.

The opportunity came gradually, then all at once. I moved to Manchester in my mid-twenties, and through the university's interfaith society began attending services, meetings and discussions across a wider range of traditions than I had ever encountered in Lucknow. Manchester is a city of remarkable religious diversity: mosques in converted terrace houses, a Jain temple in Gujarati-owned premises that doubles as a community hall, ISKCON devotees chanting in Piccadilly, Mormon elders cycling through Wythenshawe, Sufi whirling in a Zen peacemakers centre on the edge of Hulme. And in the chaplaincy at St Peter's, a rotating cast of students and seekers from a dozen traditions sitting down together every few weeks to eat curry and argue theology in the most civilised possible way.

I began attending things. Then I began taking notes. And somewhere along the way, usually on a bus or a train, I would find myself thinking: this is what Ramakrishna did. Not with the same depth, not with the same intensity, not with anything like the same meditative discipline, but with the same underlying impulse: to find out, from the inside, whether the paths go where they say they go.

## IV. The Faiths

This book has chapters on twelve encounters. I use the word encounter rather than *faith* or *religion* deliberately, because what I am describing in each case is not the tradition as a whole (which would require a library) but the specific doors I entered, and what I found in the rooms beyond them.

The Bahai faith, which opens the book, because its own theology makes the same claim as Ramakrishna's phrase, all paths are valid, and then immediately complicates it in the most interesting way. The Lotus Temple in Delhi's Kalkaji, with its nine equal entrances, is the right image for a beginning.

ISKCON, the Hare Krishna movement, which I returned to more often and more deeply than any other tradition outside my own. There is something in the bhakti path, in the specific quality of ecstatic surrender it cultivates, that seemed to keep calling me back. I attended Bhagavad Gita classes for months. I chanted on beads. I went on the London Rath Yatra in a bus from Manchester with fifty devotees and danced down the street from Hyde Park to Trafalgar Square. I would like to understand what that was.

The Mormon church, where two young elders visited me repeatedly in my flat and in their church hall in Old Trafford, patiently explaining the Book of Mormon and asking me to notice the feelings of peace and warmth that came (they were

right that something came) and where I sat in a stake conference of two thousand people in Wythenshawe and felt, despite my scepticism about the specific claims, something completely genuine about the joy in the room.

The Pentecostal UPC church, where I attended Bible study and Sunday services and a baptism and eventually a revival meeting, and where the experience of collective prayer (hands raised, tongues moving, the room becoming one breathing thing) was unlike anything I encountered anywhere else, and where I left each time both moved and unsettled, unable to decide which feeling was the more honest response.

The Jesuits, at Loyola House in Manchester, where I attended a silent retreat and had a spiritual director who told me to stay with the feeling of warmth and not pay attention to the small voice of scepticism saying *no*. I have thought about that instruction ever since.

Islam, through a study circle at the Muslim Youth Foundation on Turner Street, through the Didsbury Mosque, through a visit to the Sufi dargah of Hazrat Nizamuddin Awliya in Delhi where I stood among the petals of flowers and prayers and felt the particular quality of a tradition that has, at its heart, the idea of complete surrender, and where I remembered Ramakrishna saying the name of Allah until the presence appeared.

The Jain temple in Manchester, where the philosophy of *anekantavada* (the many-sidedness of truth, the idea that no single perspective can be complete) struck me as perhaps the most intellectually rigorous support for the *joto mot, toto path* principle I encountered anywhere.

The Quakers, whose silence I found the most difficult and the most rewarding of all the practices, and who are perhaps the only tradition in which the absence of doctrine feels not like a vacancy but like an argument.

A Buddhist-Christian retreat at Hilfield Friary in Dorset, led by a former Church of England minister who described himself as a Buddhist Christian and who led us through a guided meditation on the Passion in which each of us took the role of one of the figures present, Pilate, Mary, the soldiers, the crowd. I was assigned the role of Jesus. I will not say what happened, but I will say it was not nothing.

The Brahma Kumaris, at their Innerspace cafe near Manchester's city centre, with their white clothes and their certainty and their idea that the soul is a star of light behind the eyes, and where the specific quality of calm on offer was unlike the calm of any other tradition, cooler, more deliberate, more willed.

And the Ramakrishna Mission itself, in Lucknow and in Bangalore, which is both the frame of this book and one of its

chapters, because the Mission is Ramakrishna's institutional legacy, and visiting it is, in a strange way, like visiting the laboratory where the original experiment was conducted. The shrine room in older residential area smells of the same sandalwood. The same journal is still published. The same principle is still inscribed on the wall.

## V. What This Book Does Not Claim

I should say clearly what I did not find, or rather, what I am not claiming to have found.

I did not find that all religions are the same. They are not. The differences between Pentecostal Christianity and Quaker silence, between ISKCON devotionalism and Advaita non-dualism, between Bahai universalism and Mormon exclusivism, are not superficial differences in style wrapped around an identical centre. They are genuine differences in metaphysics, in practice, in the kind of human being each path is trying to make. To say *all paths lead to the same place* while ignoring these differences is sentimental and lazy, and does no honour to the traditions themselves.

I also did not experience, to be honest, the overwhelming convergent visions that Ramakrishna reported. I am not Ramakrishna. I did not spend years in any single tradition, let alone the depth of absorption he brought to each. What I experienced was more modest: a series of encounters with

genuine practitioners of genuine paths, all of whom seemed to be pointing at something real, and none of whom seemed to be simply deluded.

What I did find (or what I think I found, which is all any honest report can claim) is that each tradition had something that the others did not. A specific texture of the real that was only available through that door. The bhakti path offers a quality of love-soaked surrender that the Quaker silence does not offer, and the Quaker silence offers a quality of stripped attention that the bhakti path does not offer, and both of these are genuine goods, genuine encounters with something worth encountering. The question of whether they are the same encounter, approached from different angles, or different encounters with adjacent rooms in the same vast building, is the question this book circles without, I confess, finally answering.

Ramakrishna could answer it because he went deep enough into each path to reach the bedrock. I went broad instead. This is a different experiment, and it yields different results. But it is not, I think, a worthless one. Most of us in the modern world go broad rather than deep, we live in cities where a dozen traditions are available within walking distance, we have friends who believe things very different from what we believe, we are spiritually curious but insufficiently sustained. We are, most of us, less like Ramakrishna and more like a person who has

walked through the entrance of many buildings without yet choosing to live in any.

This book is for that person.

## VI. The Blog

One more thing to say about method.

The raw material for this book is a blog I kept over roughly fifteen years, beginning around 2007, in which I recorded (in the manner of someone writing for no audience except his future self) what happened when I attended these various services, meetings and retreats. The entries are documentary in the way that only unselfconscious private writing can be: they record what the speaker said, what the prasadam tasted like, what time the bus left, what I asked and what was answered, what I felt on the way home.

I have not tidied this material into something more conventionally literary than it is. What I have tried to do is find, inside the accumulation of specific detail, the shape of an inquiry: to trace, across many rooms and many years, what one person found when he tried, in his imperfect and distracted way, to verify what Ramakrishna had verified.

The blog is titled *JB*. It was never meant to be a book. Perhaps that is why it can be one now.

## VII. On Starting

Ramakrishna's teachers told him, when he first arrived at the Dakshineswar temple as a young man, to worship the goddess Kali. He was reluctant. He was, by some accounts, initially resistant to image worship. The goddess was stone.

Then he looked at her. Then he looked again. Then he began to pray. And (because this is the story of Ramakrishna) the stone eventually appeared to breathe.

I am not suggesting that this will happen to you, or to me, or that any of the practices described in this book will produce visions or ecstasies or verifiable encounters with the divine. I am only suggesting that the act of turning toward a tradition with honesty and without contempt (entering its buildings, accepting its hospitality, trying to understand from the inside what its practitioners understand) is itself a practice. And practices, over time, do something to the person who undertakes them.

What they did to me (and what Ramakrishna claimed they did to him) is what this book tries to describe.

We begin with a flower made of marble, nine petals opening to the sky.

◆

# Chapter One

## *The Garden with Nine Gates: Encountering the Bahai Faith*

> *Ye are the fruits of one tree, and the leaves of one branch. Deal ye one with another with the utmost love and harmony, with friendliness and fellowship.*
>
> — *Bahá'u'lláh*

There is a building in south Delhi that looks like a flower. Not a flower in the way architects mean when they use the word loosely (a gesture, a metaphor in concrete) but a flower with intent, with a theology of form. Its twenty-seven white marble petals open in three tiers around a central hall, the whole structure set into reflecting pools that mirror the sky. On the day I first saw it, arriving from the noise of Nehru Place and the Kalkaji colony road, I stood for a long time at the edge of the garden simply looking, the way you look at something that refuses to be hurried.

This was the Bahai Lotus Temple in Bahapur, New Delhi, and it was the first time a building made me feel, before I had spoken to a single soul inside it, that I was in the presence of a considered idea about what religion ought to be.

I had come, as I would come to so many places over the following years, as a kind of experiment. The experiment had a name, though I did not know it yet. It was the experiment of Ramakrishna.

We begin with the Bahais, because they are the faith that most insistently makes the same claim as Ramakrishna's phrase, and then complicates it in the most interesting way.

## II. The Temple

The Bahai Lotus Temple is open to all. This is not incidental to its architecture; it is the architecture. The nine entrances, symmetrically arranged, face the nine sides of the lotus form, and those nine are a doctrinal number. The Bahai World Centre in Haifa has nine terraces on Mount Carmel, the supreme governing body has nine members, and all Bahai temples in the world have nine doors. The nine, a volunteer explained to me that morning in careful English, standing outside in the Delhi winter sun, represents completeness: all directions, all approaches, none privileged.

Inside the prayer hall, the marble petals soared overhead into a cone of light. The hall was nearly silent. A recorded voice was

singing from the Bahai prayer book, and here was my first surprise. It was not singing in Arabic or Persian, the languages of the faith's origins. It was singing in Hindi. And the text, the volunteer confirmed, included a verse from the Bhagavad Gita: Arjuna being urged by Krishna to fix his mind upon the Lord.

Around the outer walls, inscriptions in Hindi and English quoted Bahá'u'lláh, the faith's nineteenth-century prophet-founder: *My love is my stronghold. He that entereth therein is safe and secure*. And: *Breathe not the sins of others so long as thou art thyself a sinner*.

On top of the temple dome, in Arabic script, was the Greatest Name (the Bahai calligraphic symbol for God) surrounded by a nine-petalled lotus.

I walked slowly around the hall, then found a place on the carpet and sat for a while. I was thinking of Ramakrishna, who had also sat in temples, indeed, who had been a priest at the Dakshineswar Kali temple for years, and who had once, after a period of practicing Islam, seen a vision of what he later described as a luminous Arab figure merging into him. I thought about what it would mean to truly practice a faith. Not to observe it from the outside, note its customs, be respectful and leave, but to practice it, to put yourself inside its logic and feel where it leads.

The Bahai faith had a temple that seemed to say: come in from whatever direction you have come. All entrances are equally valid. The lotus opens to everyone.

But I had not yet attended a fireside.

## III. The Fireside

Bahai firesides are informal gatherings, usually in someone's home, where seekers and the curious are invited to learn about the faith. The name predates central heating; they were once literally held by firesides in early twentieth-century America. By the time I attended my first one in Manchester, they were held in a living room in Fallowfield, with tea and biscuits and about seven people sitting in a circle.

N, who led the discussion, was gentle and precise. He began by explaining the Bahai view of religious history, which has a name: progressive revelation. The idea is that God does not send one message and leave humanity to puzzle over it forever. He sends teachers: Abraham, Moses, Krishna, Zoroaster, Buddha, Jesus, Muhammad, each suited to the age and the capacity of the people. Each revelation advances humanity a step. And then, in 1844, came the Bab, the Gate, who announced that a new revelation was imminent, and, in 1863, Bahá'u'lláh, the Glory of God, who brought what the Bahai faith considers the revelation for this age: the unification of humanity.

"So all the previous religions were true?" I asked.

"All were true for their time," N said. "As a child you are taught in ways appropriate to a child. As you mature, the teachings deepen. It's not that childhood was wrong. It was right for that stage."

"And what comes after Bahá'u'lláh?"

"The faith teaches that no new prophet will come for at least a thousand years."

I sat with this. It was the first tension I had felt in the beautiful symmetry of the Bahai position. The faith that most eloquently proclaims the unity of all religions simultaneously claims to be, for now, the final word. The lotus with nine equal entrances has, it turns out, one foundation.

This is not a contradiction the Bahais are unaware of. At one of the interfaith banquets I attended at St Peter's Chaplaincy in Manchester (where representatives of seven or eight faiths would speak on a common theme while we ate curry and passed rice around long tables) the Bahai speaker was always among the most articulate on the question of diversity. At one such banquet on the theme of religious diversity itself, a speaker explained the three Onenesses at the heart of the faith: the Oneness of God (all religions worship the same source, whatever name they use), the Oneness of Religion (all religions are chapters of the same unfolding story), and the Oneness of

Humanity (all people are equally deserving of truth and love). She quoted Abdul-Baha, son of Bahá'u'lláh: the diversity of religions is "the symbol and secret of perfection." She asked the room whether we preferred a garden with one kind of flower or many. Everyone smiled.

Then someone from the Islamic Society asked whether this meant the Bahai faith was simply a synthesis of other religions, a kind of spiritual pick-and-mix. Her answer was careful and firm: no. The Bahai faith has its own laws, its own prayer obligations, its own scripture. Bahá'u'lláh is not a symbol. He is a Manifestation of God. In the Bahai framework, he is the figure around whom this age of humanity's development turns. You cannot simply take the universalist language and leave the specific claims behind.

This, I began to understand, was the productive tension at the heart of the Bahai encounter with Ramakrishna's principle. *Joto mot, toto path* is a statement of radical equivalence: all sincere paths lead to the same truth. The Bahai version is more like a spiral staircase: all previous paths were valid ascents, each to a landing appropriate to its age, but the staircase continues, and Bahá'u'lláh marks the current landing.

## IV. The Book Course

Several months after my first fireside, I found myself attending a Ruhi study circle, a structured Bahai educational programme

designed to cultivate what the faith calls "human resources" for community building. I was doing it with two others, guided through Unit 1 of Book 3, on teaching children's classes.

The Ruhi materials are distinctive in tone. They are not lectures. They are workbooks, with passages to read, quotations to memorise, questions to discuss and exercises to complete. The underlying assumption is that spiritual education is not the transmission of content but the uncovering of what is already present in the student. "Human beings are created noble," the material said, in a sentence I wrote down. "Teachers have to enable them to display this nobility. Children possess gems of virtues and talents and capacities." The teacher's job is not to fill an empty vessel but to clear the dust from a gem.

I found this resonant with something I had read in Vedanta, the idea that the Self is already pure, already complete, and spiritual practice is not the acquisition of something new but the removal of what obscures what was always there. The Ruhi text went further and made the connection explicitly, comparing its approach to the Confucian model of cultivating five key relationships before worldly arts, and the Jesuit model of developing character before intellectual knowledge.

"You keep connecting this to other things," my study partner said to me once, not unkindly.

"I think that's what the faith is asking us to do," I said. "Isn't it?"

"Up to a point," they said.

That caveat, *up to a point*, is perhaps the honest account of what the Bahai faith offers the Ramakrishna seeker. It offers a framework capacious enough to hold the whole of human religious history within a single narrative. It offers institutions, the elected Local Spiritual Assembly, the National Assembly, the Universal House of Justice in Haifa, designed to make that narrative actionable rather than merely decorative. It offers a practice of community building, children's classes, junior youth groups, study circles, that embeds the theological ideas into daily life. It is, of all the faiths I encountered, the one most consciously organised around the project of making the unity of humanity a practical reality rather than a sentiment.

And it offers the firmest boundary. You can approach from any of nine doors. But inside, the laws are specific. The prayer is to be said in a specific direction. Bahá'u'lláh's word is the word.

## V. What Ramakrishna Would Have Made of It

On the day I left the Lotus Temple in Kalkaji, I walked across the road to the Kalkaji Mandir, the ancient temple to the goddess Kali that gives the colony its name. The contrast was complete. Where the Bahai temple was serene, orderly, the product of careful international committee and renowned architecture, the Kali temple was chaotic, pandas at every turn urging offerings, a red dupatta draped over the goddess, priests shouting, beggars

at the gate, the smell of incense and marigolds thick in the air, devotees pressing forward with coins and sweets.

I thought of Ramakrishna, who had been a priest at a Kali temple. Who had wept before the goddess with such longing that the stone had seemed to him to breathe. Who had then, without leaving that devotion behind, turned and found the same presence in the Allah of the Sufi mystics, in the Christ of the Christian scriptures.

What would he have made of the Bahai faith?

I think he would have loved the Lotus Temple. He would have sat in its cool marble hall and found the same presence he found everywhere. He might have been moved by the prayer singing from the Bhagavad Gita. He would have appreciated (as a man who had himself moved through many forms of practice) the Bahai insistence that all the prophets were true, that the divine speaks in whatever tongue the age requires.

And I suspect he would have been troubled, gently, by the thousand-year waiting period. By the sense that the path had arrived, that the revelation was complete for now. Not because he was hostile to revelation, he wasn't, but because his own experience had been that the divine was inexhaustible and perpetually available, not a message delivered at a specific moment to a specific person but a presence continuously erupting in whoever searched with sufficient sincerity.

The Bahai faith says: all doors are open, all paths were true, and the destination of this age is here. Ramakrishna says: all doors are open, all paths are true, and the destination is wherever you arrive when you have walked far enough.

These are nearly the same thing. The difference is the word *nearly* which in theology, as in love, carries a great deal of weight.

## VI. A Note on Beginning

I am starting this book with the Bahais not because they were the first faith I encountered in my experiment, they were not, but because their framework names the question the whole book is trying to answer. If all religions are chapters of the same book, is it possible to read them all? If all paths lead to the same mountain, what does it feel like to walk more than one of them, not sequentially but overlappingly, in the same decade of your life, in the same city, with the same longings?

The Lotus Temple is the right image for a beginning because it insists, architecturally, that there is no wrong entrance. You approach from wherever you stand.

I approached from Lucknow, from a Bengali family, from the Ramakrishna Mission bookshop where I had spent hours as a young man reading about Vivekananda's letters from America, from a software job in Manchester and a persistent feeling that

there were more rooms in the house of the spirit than I had been shown.

Walk in. The petals open from inside.

◆

# Chapter Two

## *Submission and the Presence: Encountering Islam*

> *I have cast duality aside and I see the two worlds as one. I seek the one, I know the one, I see the one, I call the one.*
>
> — *Jalaluddin Rumi*

> *He who has no kindness for the young and no respect for the old is not one of us.*
>
> — *Hadith of the Prophet Muhammad (Tirmidhi)*

### I. The Presence in the Passage

In the Nizamuddin neighbourhood of south Delhi, on a lane that leads away from the metro station through a compressed world of flower sellers, cap vendors, beggars, and small restaurants selling nihari and haleem, there is a medieval complex containing the dargah of Hazrat Nizamuddin Auliya (one of the most important Sufi shrines on the subcontinent) and, a few steps away, the dargah of his disciple Amir Khusro, the poet and

musician who is considered the father of the Hindustani classical tradition. You remove your shoes at the entrance. A flower seller will offer to store them for free if you buy a small packet of roses and sweets, ten rupees, to offer at the shrine. A kind man lent me a white cap to cover my head. I had forgotten to bring one.

I walked the narrow lane into the dargah with the packet of roses in my hand, joining a slow procession of people who moved with the particular quality of concentrated reverence that I have noticed only in places where human beings have been praying in the same spot for many centuries. The marble was cool underfoot. There were carved lattice screens, and through them the smell of attar and incense. At the tomb of Hazrat Nizamuddin (who died in 1325, having spent decades in Delhi as a Sufi master of the Chishti order, teaching that the love of God was the only true knowledge) people stood in silence, or whispered prayers, or touched the embroidered cloth draped over the tomb and then touched their faces.

I stood there for a while. I prayed, not in any particular language, not with any particular form, but in the way I had been learning, slowly, to pray in spaces that were not my own tradition's spaces: by becoming quiet and pointing the attention inward and waiting to see what was there.

Something was there.

I cannot say more than that without sounding either fraudulent or mystical in the lazy sense. What I can say is that the quality of the presence in that dargah was distinct from what I have felt in Hindu temples, in churches, in the Bahai prayer hall, in the Hare Krishna temple. It had a different texture. Cooler, perhaps. More austere. More like an open sky than a room. And yet unmistakably the same kind of thing: the sense of a contact with something that exceeded my own consciousness.

I then walked to the smaller dargah of Amir Khusro, a few steps away, and stood before his tomb. Khusro, who died in 1325 in grief at the death of his master, wrote in Persian and Braj Bhasha and Hindi and Punjabi and invented musical forms, the qawwali among them, that are still performed at Sufi shrines across the subcontinent every Thursday night. He was, in some ways, the perfect embodiment of what the Chishti Sufis stood for: a porous boundary between traditions, a music that invited everyone in, a theology of love that had no need of walls.

After Khusro's tomb I stood for a while in the courtyard, watching a group of men pray in the large mosque next to the mazar. The call to prayer was long over, but they had come anyway, finding their place in the rows, pressing their foreheads to the ground in a gesture of complete prostration that I had always, without quite knowing why, found more moving than almost any other act of worship I had seen.

I thought of Ramakrishna, who had practiced Islam here, not here specifically, in this courtyard, but in this tradition, this quality of surrender. Who had repeated the name of Allah. Who had, according to his disciples, seen a luminous figure that he understood to be the Prophet, and felt it merge into him.

I thought: he was right that there is something here. But I was not sure I could name what it was.

## II. Turner Street

The Muslim Youth Foundation on Turner Street in Manchester occupied a building I had walked past several times without knowing what it was, a converted terrace in the dense student and immigrant geography of the city centre, between Oxford Road and Piccadilly, a part of Manchester that has always absorbed newcomers. I arrived an hour late to a talk that had started at seven. The door was open. I found a place at the back of a prayer hall divided by a partition: about twenty men on one side, twenty women on the other, both facing a shaikh who sat at the front and spoke with the measured confidence of someone who has thought carefully about his subject for a long time.

The topic was halal, what is permitted, and I had expected, if I am honest, something legalistic, a list of rules. What I got instead was a lesson in the internal logic of a moral system.

The shaikh began with a caution: we should be very careful, he said, about calling anyone a kuffar, an unbeliever, because the consequences within Islamic law are severe: they affect inheritance, marriage, standing in the community. The bar for that judgement should be high. If a person is weak and doesn't pray five times a day, they are a sinner, but still a Muslim. Weakness is not disbelief.

This struck me as, among other things, compassionate. It built a large space for human imperfection inside the structure of the faith.

Then he spoke about what the tradition calls the five necessities (the things that Islamic law is fundamentally designed to protect, and for the sake of which even normally forbidden things can become obligatory. Preserve your religion. Preserve your life. Preserve your wealth. Preserve your honour. Preserve your sanity. If you are dying of hunger in a desert and only pork is available, he said, it is not merely permitted to eat it) it is obligatory. Only as much as necessary. But the preservation of life takes precedence over the dietary law. The law serves life, not the other way around.

I wrote this down. In the margin of my notes I wrote: *the law is a container, not the thing contained.*

The question period was lively. Someone asked about halal meat in British supermarkets, whether, if sufficient halal was

available in the UK, it was ever acceptable to eat non-halal. The shaikh's answer was nuanced: it depends on your level, on the context. For the purpose of building bridges with non-Muslim friends, some latitude is possible. The people of the Book, Jews and Christians, are mentioned specifically in the Quran as those whose food is permitted to Muslims and whose company is allowed. Islam, said the shaikh, is not a fortress. It has doors.

Someone else asked about the equality of men and women. The answer was longer and less satisfying, in my view, though I understood that I was hearing a position from within a tradition rather than a defence addressed to outsiders, and that these are different things.

Walking home along Oxford Road afterwards, past the kebab shops and the late-night halal chicken places and the clusters of students, I found myself thinking about the five necessities. There is something beautiful, I thought, in a moral system that begins not with prohibition but with what must be protected. That places sanity alongside religion and life as things worth preserving with the full force of law. That acknowledges, built into its structure, that human beings will be weak and that weakness is not the same as abandonment.

## III. The Character of the Prophet

The Didsbury Mosque in south Manchester, a Victorian church building, its spire replaced by a minaret, its stained glass

windows still intact behind the ablution area, hosted a series of public talks called the Discovering Islam Exhibition. I attended on a summer evening in 2008, when the topic was character and virtue.

The speaker was careful and warm. He began with a survey of how character is taught in the contemporary world: eighty percent of the time, he said, parents tell children what to do and what not to do. What they should be doing instead is showing the child good character. Not commanding virtue but embodying it. The word he used for this was *uswah*, example, model, and the supreme example, in Islamic understanding, is the Prophet himself.

He quoted a verse that I found arresting: *The Prophet's essential character was the Quran*. Not: the Prophet followed the Quran. Not: the Prophet recited the Quran. His character *was* the Quran. The text and the life were the same thing. The scripture was not a set of instructions he followed, it was what he was.

Then the speaker moved through the specific virtues that Islamic ethics identifies as rooted in this model. Respect for elders. A hadith from Tirmidhi: *He who has no kindness for the young and no respect for the old is not one of us*. A hadith from Dawud: *Respect for a grey-haired Muslim is part of respect for Allah*. These were not presented as nice sentiments but as theological claims: that how you treat the elderly person in front of you is a form of how you treat God.

Respect for parents. Here the speaker's voice carried more weight. The Quran, he said, places the obligation to honour parents immediately after the obligation to worship God alone: most important is to worship Allah and join nothing to Him, and next to that, be good to parents. The worst crimes listed in the Quran (ascribing partners to Allah, disobeying parents, killing an innocent soul, false testimony) place the parent in the company of the absolute. He quoted: *Paradise lies at the feet of the mother*.

I am a Bengali man with a mother who is still alive in Lucknow. I do not think I fully appreciated, sitting in that mosque, how much of my own ethical formation was already structured around ideas that overlapped completely with what he was describing. The obligation to parents. The specific weight of the mother. The idea that the treatment of the person immediately in front of you (the elder, the neighbour, the hungry man) is not separable from the treatment of the divine.

He ended with the neighbours. The Prophet, he said, was asked by the Angel Gabriel about neighbours so many times, and so insistently, that he began to think the neighbour might be included in the laws of inheritance. And a saying of the Prophet: *He is not a true believer who eats to his fill while his neighbour goes hungry*. Not: he is not a good Muslim. Not: he has committed a sin. He is not, in the fullest sense, a *believer* at all.

The hunger of the neighbour is not a social problem adjacent to faith. It is a test of faith's reality.

Walking out into the Didsbury evening (the suburban street, the restaurant smells, the ordinary summer light) I thought: there is an ethical architecture here that is both completely specific to this tradition and completely recognisable to any tradition that has taken seriously the connection between the vertical relationship with God and the horizontal relationship with the person standing next to you.

## IV. Surrender

Islam means, at its root, submission. The Arabic root *s-l-m* carries both *salaam*, peace, and *islam*, submission, in it. The peace and the submission are not separable. You get the peace by doing the submitting.

I had heard this explained several times, at several of the interfaith banquets at St Peter's Chaplaincy where Muslim speakers would take the podium alongside the Buddhist and the Sikh and the Bahai. At the banquet on peace, the Muslim chaplain said something that stayed with me: that the word *jihad* is frequently misunderstood, and that it has three layers. The first is the struggle against injustice in the world, the external form. The second is the use of speech and writing to oppose what is wrong. The third, the innermost layer, and the most important, is simply the thought in the heart: *I abhor this*.

The most fundamental jihad is interior. It is the refusal to be at peace with what is wrong inside yourself.

At the same banquet, when the topic turned to capitalism and profit, he described the Islamic concept of *zakaat* (the obligatory giving of a portion of accumulated wealth to the community) in a way I had not heard before. It is not, he said, a tax. It is a recognition that every pound you earn contains a contribution from other members of society. You did not earn your wealth alone. The zakaat is simply the acknowledgement of that fact, made concrete. The obligation to give is built into the very understanding of what wealth is: it was never entirely yours to begin with.

I thought of the Jain concept of *aparigraha*, non-possessiveness, which I had encountered in Manchester's Jain temple and which rests on the same intuition. And of the Gita's instruction on action without attachment to results. The idea that what you call yours is not entirely yours, that ownership is provisional and stewardship is the more accurate description of your relationship to wealth, seems to surface independently across several traditions. When the same idea appears in Jain ethics and Islamic law and Bhagavad Gita metaphysics, it is at minimum worth asking whether they are pointing at the same perception of the world.

## V. Rumi, or: The Tradition Behind the Tradition

On the seventeenth of December (the anniversary of Rumi's death in 1273) a small group of us gathered in a house in Manchester belonging to one of the founders of the local Zen Peacemakers circle. There was a teacher who had studied with Sufi teachers and who spoke about Rumi's life with the easy familiarity of someone who had lived with the material for years, and about eight or nine others, a mixed group in the way that Zen Peacemakers gatherings tended to be: Buddhist, Jewish, Christian, loosely spiritual. Our host would play classical music between the poems. There was tea.

He began with Rumi's biography. Born in what is now Afghanistan in 1207, he grew up in Persia and settled in Konya, in what is now Turkey, where he was already an established Islamic scholar and jurist. Then, in 1244, he met a wandering dervish named Shams-i-Tabrizi, and everything changed. Shams became Rumi's spiritual master. They spent forty days together in retreat. What emerged from that retreat was, over the following decades, one of the most extraordinary bodies of mystical poetry in any language: the *Masnavi*, the *Diwan-i Shams*, the rubais, a torrent of verse about the love of God that is also, inseparably, a record of the love between a teacher and a student, and the grief of losing the teacher.

He described the Sufi orders and their different characters. The Mevlevi order, Rumi's own, is, he said, relatively free, close in some ways to Zen: it does not prescribe rigid stages of practice

in the way that some lineages do. The Naqshbandi is large and widespread. The Chishti, the order of Nizamuddin Auliya, took root in India and produced the musical tradition of qawwali, the devotional singing I had heard echoing faintly in that Delhi courtyard. Some lineages, he said, are very rooted in conventional Islam: you must follow the shariah before you can be initiated into the deeper practices. Others are more porous. The Mevlevi, for example.

Then he read from Rumi. Four poems corresponding to the four stages of spiritual evolution in the Sufi understanding: the beginning, when the ego is strong and the divine is distant; the middle stages, when love begins to dissolve the boundaries of the self; and the final stage, when the distinction between self and God becomes, if not meaningless, then at least no longer the most important thing.

He read a couplet that I wrote down in full that night and have not forgotten since:

> *What is to be done, O Muslims? For I do not recognise myself. I have cast duality aside and see the two worlds as one.*

I do not recognise myself. This is the voice of someone for whom the spiritual path has succeeded so completely that the person who began the journey is no longer the person speaking. The ego has been, at least partially, dissolved, not into nothingness, but

into a larger recognition. The two worlds as one: this world and the next, the human and the divine, the self and the beloved. Not the same, but no longer separated by the distance that ordinary consciousness maintains between them.

He then showed us the posture of Sufi whirling. How you stand on a single foot, the other foot as the pivot, turning clockwise in slow, deepening rotation. How the hands begin folded across the chest as a symbol of unity and then open outward (one hand reaching up toward heaven, one turned down toward the earth) as a symbol of the dervish as a channel between the two. How before you begin, you bow to the teacher and to each other, acknowledging the divinity in the one you face.

We tried it. Seven or eight people in a Manchester living room, slightly self-conscious, slightly laughing at our own awkwardness, slowly turning. Our host was playing something by a German composer I didn't recognise, grand and oceanic, appropriate to the creation of the universe, which is apparently the stage it represented. I managed perhaps thirty seconds of whirling before I had to stop, dizzy and grinning.

The point, he said, is not the spinning. The point is the state the spinning induces: a particular dissolution of ordinary cognition, a thinning of the membrane between the self and whatever is larger than the self. The body becomes a tool for an experience that the body, on its own, cannot produce. The discipline is a method of opening.

We sang *Bismillah ir-rahman ir-rahim* (In the name of God, the compassionate, the merciful) together, several times, until the room settled into something that, for lack of a better word, I can only call a different quality of attention. Not trance. Not ecstasy. Just a room of people who were, for a few minutes, all pointing in the same direction.

## VI. What Ramakrishna Found

The account in the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna of his practice of Islam is brief but specific. He lived for a time in the Muslim manner: eating food prepared in the Muslim way, repeating the name of Allah, wearing a cloth as Muslims wore it, keeping his mind fixed on the formless divine that Islam emphasises and that is, in some ways, quite different from the form-loving devotionalism that was his native spiritual temperament. He thought of the Prophet. And he reported, at the end of this period, the vision of a luminous Arab figure, radiant, compassionate, serene, that moved toward him and merged into him.

His disciples noted that during this period he could not approach the Kali temple. The goddess's image, which was the centre of his entire devotional life, seemed suddenly foreign, even offensive to his spiritual sensibility. He was, in other words, not performing Islam as an experiment while remaining

securely located in his Hinduism. He had actually moved into the tradition. The tradition had moved into him.

This is the part of Ramakrishna's experiment that is most challenging to replicate, and most important to think about honestly. What I did (attending talks at the MYF and the Didsbury Mosque, standing at the Nizamuddin dargah, sitting with a Rumi evening in a Manchester living room) was not this. It was engagement, genuine engagement, but it was not the kind of total inhabitation that Ramakrishna describes. I remained, throughout, a Hindu-background person visiting Islam with curiosity and respect. I did not stop being able to approach my own tradition's images.

But I think Ramakrishna's experience points at something real about what Islam offers, which is at least partially available at the surface level I inhabited. Islam, more than perhaps any other tradition I encountered, makes a total claim. Not in the aggressive sense, though that sense exists, and the tradition's history includes plenty of it, but in the sense that it proposes a complete reorganisation of the self around the axis of submission to the divine. The five daily prayers are not devotional supplements to an otherwise secular day. They are interruptions of the secular day, five times, by the insistence that something other than your own agenda is real and prior. The direction of prayer, toward Mecca, toward the Kaaba, the first

house of God, is not a symbol. It is an actual direction. Your body faces a specific point on the earth.

This specificity, this insistence on the concrete and the directional, is very different from the Vedantic traditions I grew up adjacent to, which tend toward the formless and the directional only as a concession to human limitation. For Advaita Vedanta, all forms are ultimately provisional. For Islam, the direction of prayer is real because the world is real and God is its creator and the specific body that you inhabit in the specific world must be oriented toward its source.

I found this, and find it still, both alien and clarifying. The alienness is genuine: I am not a person for whom the five prayers would feel natural, for whom the ablution rituals before prayer would feel like necessity rather than habit. But the clarifying quality is also genuine: there is something in the Islamic insistence on the body's orientation, on the concrete act of prostration, on the requirement that wealth acknowledge its own porousness, that addresses a tendency I notice in myself and in the Hindu-adjacent spiritual world I come from, a tendency toward abstraction, toward the formless, toward the idea of practice rather than the practice itself.

Standing with my forehead on the cool marble of the Nizamuddin courtyard (which I did not do, but which I watched others do, with an attention I have not quite been able to put down since) seemed to me to be doing something very specific

to the person who did it. Something about the literalness of the gesture: the highest point of the body touching the ground. The crown of the head, where Vedanta places the highest chakra, the point of divine connection, brought to the floor. Not as defeat. As offering.

## VII. The Problem of the Wall

I want to be honest about what I did not find comfortable.

At the interfaith banquets, the Muslim speaker's position on homosexuality (presented plainly, without malice, as the shariah position) was that it was forbidden, and that those who engaged in it under Islamic law would face consequences. The speaker was not hostile. He was honest. But the honesty was about a hardness in the tradition that I could not simply absorb and move past.

At the MYF talk, a question about the equality of men and women got a long and careful answer that was, in the end, an argument for complementarity rather than equality in the modern sense, different roles, different responsibilities, each honoured. I understood the internal logic. I could see the tradition as a coherent whole in which this position made sense. I could not fully agree with it.

I raise this not to score points against Islam, every tradition I encountered in this experiment has hardnesses, including my

own. The ISKCON position on caste, the Mormon position on women and the priesthood, the Catholic position on contraception, every living tradition carries things that are, from the outside, and sometimes from the inside, indefensible or at least not readily defensible. What I want to resist is the comfortable universalism that smooths over these roughnesses in the service of a pleasant conclusion.

The *joto mot, toto path* principle does not mean that all paths are identical or that all their contents are equally admirable. It means that each path, walked with sincerity toward the divine, reaches the divine. It is a claim about the destination, not a blanket endorsement of every mile of the road.

What I took from Islam (and what I believe Ramakrishna found in it) is a specific quality of the divine encounter that is not available in the same form anywhere else: the vast, cool, directional, surrendered openness of a tradition that has built its entire architecture around the fact of God's absolute priority. The submission that is simultaneously the peace. The prostration that is simultaneously the height.

I do not recognise myself, Rumi wrote. I have cast duality aside.

I have not cast duality aside. But I have stood in a lane in Delhi with borrowed flowers in my hand, in a place where people have been casting it aside for seven hundred years, and felt what the air is like there.

# Chapter Three

## *The Radical Possibility of Being Wrong: Encountering Jainism*

> *Jainism believes in the spiritual independence and equality of all life forms. Non-violence to every living being is its first and final word.*
>
> — *from the Jain Samaj Manchester information board*

> *Conquer your self, for the self, once conquered, becomes your greatest ally. The unconquered self is your most dangerous enemy.*
>
> — *Mahavira, 24th Tirthankara*

### I. The Hill

There is a hill in the Karnataka countryside, about a hundred and sixty kilometres south-west of Bangalore, called Indragiri. It is not large (six hundred steps to the summit, barefoot, which takes perhaps forty minutes) but it rises sharply enough from the surrounding flatness that you feel, climbing it, a clear sense of leaving ordinary ground behind. The steps are old and

uneven, worn smooth in the middle by centuries of feet. On either side, cut into the rock face or sheltered under carved stone canopies, are small Jain shrines, the *bastis* and *basadis*, dedicated to various of the twenty-four Tirthankaras, the ford-makers, those who have crossed the river of existence from suffering to liberation and who stand, by their example, as crossing points for those who come after.

I climbed it on a morning in early spring, having come by overnight bus from Bangalore via Hassan, then local bus to Channarayapatna, then the last seven kilometres to the town of Shravanabelagola. I had taken off my slippers at the base of the hill as instructed, pulled on some socks against the rough stone, and started up. The Karnataka light was already strong even at that hour. There were other pilgrims on the steps, mostly Jain families in white, moving slowly, some with folded hands, some in silence.

At the summit stood what I had come to see: the monolithic statue of Bahubali, known as Gomateshwara, carved from a single granite outcrop in 981 CE on the orders of a Ganga dynasty general-turned-monk. It is eighteen metres tall (roughly the height of a six-storey building) and it depicts Bahubali standing in a posture of perfect stillness, arms at his sides, vines climbing his legs and arms from the long years he spent in motionless meditation before achieving liberation. His eyes are open, half-lidded, serene. Ant hills rise to his shins.

Serpents coil at his feet. The creepers have wound past his elbows. He is absolutely still, and the world keeps moving around him.

His expression, when I finally stood before it, was the most specific thing about him: not the blankness of a stone face, but something I can only describe as a completed serenity, the face of someone for whom the struggle is genuinely over. Not suppressed, not deferred. Over.

I stood there longer than I had intended. *Felt like just staying there and meditating,* I wrote in my blog that evening, without ceremony or elaboration, which is, I think, the most accurate thing I could have said.

What is it that Bahubali's face communicates? He was the son of Rishabha, the first Tirthankara, and the brother of Bharata, who became the first emperor of India. When their father left the world to become a wandering monk, the brothers divided the kingdom. Then Bharata asked Bahubali to submit to his sovereignty. Bahubali refused, not out of pride, exactly, but out of an understanding that submission to another human being, even a brother, was inconsistent with the spiritual path he was trying to walk. They fought. The tradition says the battle was settled not by armies but by single combat, wrestling, staring contests, water-fights, and that Bahubali won each round. Then, standing victorious, he suddenly saw the absurdity of it: he had won a kingdom he had never wanted, by defeating a brother he

loved, in a contest that had nothing to do with liberation. He stood there, on the battlefield, and simply stopped. He gave everything back. He went into the forest and stood without moving for a year, until he reached the other shore.

The vines grew up his legs while he stood there. He let them.

## II. The Badminton Court

The Jain Samaj temple in Manchester occupied a converted building near the city's southern suburbs, a community hall whose badminton court doubled as a shrine room and meeting space, the demarcation shifting depending on which function was in use. When I arrived with a friend on a Thursday evening, it was in shrine mode: the badminton lines still faintly visible on the floor beneath the devotees' feet, the net poles stored against the far wall, the central space given over to the Shwetambar images of the Tirthankaras in their carved wooden shrine.

The Shwetambar images, the name means white-clad, had open eyes and seated postures, and their feet were the objects of veneration rather than their faces: touching the feet of the liberated ones is the gesture of respect, since the liberated being is beyond needing to look back at you, and it is the path they walked, the ground they touched on their way to liberation, that matters. The Digambar images, sky-clad, naked, the other major Jain sect, have no eyes at all, and stand erect. The philosophy is the same in both traditions, someone explained to me. The

dispute is ancient, technical, and apparently genuinely difficult to resolve.

The programme began at six with Bhakti: Gujarati devotional singing with drums and cymbals, the room filling quickly with a warm, percussive energy that surprised me, given that I had come expecting something more austere from a tradition whose central principle is non-violence and whose monks wear cloth masks to avoid accidentally inhaling insects. The Jains I met in Manchester were Gujarati merchants, the tradition is concentrated in Gujarat and Rajasthan, and many of the community had come to Britain in the second half of the twentieth century, bringing their temples, their strictly vegetarian kitchens, their gold-thread saris, and their philosophical sophistication with them.

At half-past six a lady gave a talk in Gujarati, which someone translated for us in a steady, patient murmur. The topic was how to practice steadily: the reminder that when making offerings to the Tirthankaras, one should be careful never to harm even a flower or a plant, the act of worship must not itself become an act of violence. I found this remarkable. The ethics were being applied recursively: the means of devotion must be as careful as the life you are trying to build through devotion. You cannot arrive at non-violence by violent routes.

After the arati (the lamp ceremony, one man in a turban and long scarf circling the flame before the images while others

danced and sang) we sat down to eat. Rice, curry, spiced apple pickle, yoghurt, lassi, chapati with ghee. It was magnificent. The Jains I know are, in my experience, the best vegetarian cooks on earth, and this Gujarati feast was confirmation. We talked over the food to whoever would sit with us.

A man explained the four principles of Jain life. He said (and I have thought about this phrasing many times since) that anyone, regardless of the tradition they belonged to, could live a Jain lifestyle by following these four things. Non-violence: do not harm living beings. Non-possessiveness: do not consume more than you need. *Asteya*: do not steal. Do not lie. He said this calmly, not as a challenge or a recruitment. As information. As though he were telling me the opening hours of the temple.

I thought: these four are not specifically Jain. They are in the Yoga Sutras of Patanjali as the first four of the five yamas. They appear in Buddhist precepts. They map approximately onto the Ten Commandments. They are, in some form, in every ethical tradition I had encountered. The Jain contribution is not the list but the *depth* to which each principle is taken, and in particular the first one, which in Jainism is not a commandment but a cosmology.

## III. The Candle

Several weeks later I returned to the Manchester Jain temple for the Sunday satsang, arriving after missing the four o'clock

meditation. The instruction for that session, someone told me, had been to gaze at a candle flame without blinking (or blinking as little as possible) while also observing the breath. The two together, they said, would help clear the mind of thoughts and settle it into awareness. Next week's meditation would be conducted in English.

The satsang that followed was a question-and-answer session on Jain philosophy, conducted in Gujarati with continuous translation for us, a generosity I have never forgotten, given that we were guests with no particular claim on anyone's time or patience.

The session opened with an orientation that, in the most economical possible way, established the entire metaphysical framework: we are the soul, not the body. Although we identify with the body and habitually react to it, this identification is the source of all our suffering and our bondage. The soul is the true self, the base of everything. The soul has no senses (it is the light that illuminates the senses, not the thing illuminated. When we die, the body dissolves. The soul carries forward what it has accumulated) which is karma, understood in Jainism not as a moral bookkeeping system but as a literal physical substance: fine particles of matter that cling to the soul when it reacts to the world, obscuring its natural luminosity.

The analogy given for the soul was a candle in the dark, whose light makes the five senses visible and meaningful. Without the

soul, the senses would have no meaning (they are its instruments, and they are left behind when it departs the body. What the tradition is trying to do, through its ethics and its meditation practices, is to thin the accumulated karma) not by good actions accumulating positive karma, as in some Hindu frameworks, but by stopping the reactions that generate karma at all. The goal is not to tip the scales in your favour. The goal is to step off the scales entirely.

An analogy was given that I have used in conversations ever since: the prescription glasses. If you have myopia, the optician gives you glasses, which correct your vision temporarily. But the root condition, the shape of the eye, is unchanged. Listening to Jain philosophy, or any philosophy, is like putting on the glasses: it corrects your perception temporarily, lets you see more clearly for a while. But the actual work, the meditation, the practice, the encounter with a genuine teacher, is like treating the underlying condition. The words are not the thing. They point at it.

Someone asked what the proper response was when another person hurts you. The answer, given without apparent struggle, was: observe, do not react. The person who hit you did so because of your past karma, the encounter was, in this framework, not accidental but a settling of accounts from some earlier action. Reacting with anger creates new karma. Simply observing (feeling the pain, knowing it, and not responding

from within it) allows the karma to dissolve without generating more. The soul, the speaker said, is completely independent of the internal and external sense organs. It is the observer. It is not what is being observed.

Then came the analogy that stopped me entirely.

Imagine, said the speaker, that you are watching a film in a cinema. Dolby Digital sound, wide screen. You know it is a film. And yet, if you identify with the characters (if you allow the story to take hold of you) you find yourself frightened, or moved to tears, or exhilarated. Your body responds as if what is happening on the screen is happening to you. But it is not happening to you. It is happening to projected light on a flat surface. The world we inhabit, said the speaker, is exactly like this. We have identified so completely with the film that we have forgotten we are sitting in the dark, watching.

I looked at my companion. They were writing something in their notebook.

What struck me was not that this idea was unfamiliar, versions of it appear in Advaita Vedanta, in Buddhist philosophy, in Plato's cave. What struck me was the specific quality of the Jain framing: the absolute insistence on the independence and primacy of the soul, combined with the absolute insistence on the reality and sentience of all other souls. You are not the film, but the other beings in the film are real. This is not solipsism.

The consequence of understanding your own nature as a pure observer is not detachment from the world, it is a radical care for every sentient thing within it, precisely because every sentient thing is, at its core, another such observer, another such light, equally real and equally obscured by its accumulated karma.

This is where Jain ahimsa comes from. Not from a rule. From a metaphysic.

## IV. The Most Ancient Radicalism

Jainism is among the oldest living religious traditions on earth. Its origins predate Buddhism, Mahavira, the twenty-fourth and most recent Tirthankara, was a contemporary of the Buddha in the fifth century BCE, but the tradition he reformed and reinvigorated stretches back much further, to Rishabha, the first Tirthankara, whose existence is considered legendary or pre-historical. The tradition's claim is essentially that it has always existed: that liberation from the cycle of birth and death has always been available, and that from time to time, across vast cycles of cosmic time, a being achieves it and becomes a ford-maker, a Tirthankara, whose life demonstrates the crossing to others.

The cosmology is staggering in its scale. The universe is understood as going through immense cycles of ascent and decline (the speaker at the Manchester satsang compared it,

without apparent irony, to a big bang and big crunch. In each cycle, twenty-four Tirthankaras arise. Mahavira is the twenty-fourth of this cycle. The next cycle's first Tirthankara has not yet been born. The tradition will continue without a living ford-maker until that time) guided by the teachings, the example of those who have already crossed, and the community of monks and laypeople who try to live by the principles they demonstrated.

What this cosmology means, among other things, is that Jainism does not have a God in the sense of a creator or a sustainer of the universe. The universe runs according to its own laws. The Tirthankaras are not gods, they are liberated souls, beyond the possibility of intervening in the world once they have achieved liberation. You cannot pray to them for help. What you can do is contemplate them: meditate on their quality of pure awareness, their achieved serenity, and allow that contemplation to point your own awareness in the same direction. The worship is not petitionary. It is educational.

I found this clarifying in a way I had not expected. I had grown up with devotional religion, the gods of the Hindu tradition who respond to prayer, who can be pleased or displeased, who have relationships with their devotees. The ISKCON Krishna I had been encountering in Manchester temples was a god in the fullest sense: a person, with preferences, with love, with the capacity to intervene. The Jain Tirthankara is something

different: an achieved state, a demonstration, a direction. The teaching is not *pray to me*. It is *look at what is possible*.

Ramakrishna worshipped Kali with a personal devotion so intense that the stone seemed to breathe. He could not have related to the Jain Tirthankara in the same way. And yet the Jain tradition would say: the goal Ramakrishna was pointing toward (the dissolution of the ego, the direct contact with something beyond the ordinary self) is the same goal the Tirthankaras achieved, arrived at by a different method. The devotional path and the path of pure observation are different roads up the same hill.

## V. The Red Temple

The Digambar Jain Lal Mandir in Chandni Chowk, Delhi, was built during the reign of Shah Jahan, which means it is roughly contemporary with the Red Fort that faces it across the main road, and that it has been here, in the heart of Mughal-era Delhi, for nearly four hundred years. It is red sandstone, hence the name, and it sits in a narrow lane dense with silver shops and spice merchants and the compressed commercial energy of old Delhi.

I left my shoes and my bag and my belt at the entrance, the request for the belt surprised me at first, until I understood that metal, in this context, is associated with harm; the tradition's attentiveness to what you carry into the sacred space extends to

hardware, and walked into the central hall. The Digambar images stood in the traditional sky-clad style: fully naked, eyeless, perfectly upright, arms slightly away from the sides, the pose of someone who has dropped everything. Next to the main hall were shrines to Parshvanath, the twenty-third Tirthankara, and to Mahavira, the twenty-fourth.

What struck me in the Lal Mandir more than the images was a room I found toward the back of the complex: an air-conditioned meditation hall, built inside what felt like a cave, the ceiling low and curved, the lighting dim, the sound of the street entirely absent. There were cushions on the floor. Several people were sitting in silence. I sat down.

I have sat in many meditation spaces across many traditions. Each has a specific quality (the Quaker meeting house has a quality of stripped attention, the Hindu temple sanctum a quality of concentrated devotional heat, the Bahai prayer hall a cool serenity. This room was different again: it had the quality of something removed from time, as though the ordinary pressures of cause and effect had been, for the duration of sitting in it, temporarily suspended. The air conditioning was part of it, practically speaking. But there was something else) perhaps the accumulated quality of many people sitting in this specific room for this specific purpose over many years, perhaps simply the architecture, the cave-like containment that mimicked, in a

small urban building, the forest hermitages where the ancient Jain monks had stood motionless for months.

I sat for perhaps twenty minutes. Then I went back out into the Chandni Chowk afternoon, the noise and the silver and the smell of spices, and stood blinking in the light.

## VI. Anekantavada

The philosophical doctrine for which Jainism is perhaps most distinctive is called *anekantavada*, the many-sidedness of reality, and its practical application is called *syadvada*: the doctrine of conditional predication, which holds that every statement about reality must be qualified with the word *syat*: perhaps, or from one perspective. No single statement about reality is simply and absolutely true. Every statement is true from a particular vantage point, under particular conditions. Reality itself is too complex and too multidimensional to be captured in any single proposition, however careful.

This is not relativism, and it is important to understand why. Anekantavada does not say that all statements are equally true or that truth doesn't exist. It says that truth is larger than any single perspective on it, and that the appropriate epistemic attitude is one of systematic humility: knowing that what you can see from where you stand is real, and also knowing that it is partial.

The classic illustration is the blind men and the elephant, a story that appears in both Buddhist and Jain traditions, and which Ramakrishna himself used. Each man touches a different part of the elephant and reports a different reality: it is a wall, it is a rope, it is a pillar, it is a fan. Each is right. None is complete. The error is not in the touching but in the claim to totality.

What anekantavada means for the question this book is asking (whether the different religious paths are all valid approaches to the same truth) is significant. Jainism, more than any other tradition I encountered, provides a rigorous philosophical foundation for the *joto mot, toto path* principle. It does not merely say, as a generous sentiment, that all paths lead to God. It says, as a matter of careful epistemology, that any claim to have the complete and final truth about reality (including about the nature of liberation and how to reach it) must be held with the qualifier *syat*. Perhaps. From this perspective. As far as I can see.

The consequence for interfaith dialogue is radical. It means that the Jain tradition is committed, at the level of its deepest philosophical principles, to the genuine possibility that other traditions have seen something it has not. Not as a concession, not as tolerance, but as an intellectual obligation. If reality is many-sided, then the tradition that has seen the most of it is the one that has listened most carefully to the perspectives it has not itself occupied.

I mentioned anekantavada at one of the Manchester interfaith banquets, in the context of a discussion about whether the different religions were really saying the same thing. The Jain man who was present smiled and said: the interesting question is not whether they say the same thing. The interesting question is which aspects of reality each one has seen most clearly. They are all partial. They are all real. The task is not synthesis. The task is listening.

## VII. Bahubali, Again

On the hill at Shravanabelagola, after standing before Gomateshwara for longer than I had planned, I walked back down to the smaller hill opposite, Chandragiri, where there are dozens of ancient Jain temples, some dating to the Mauryan dynasty of the third century BCE: stone buildings that have been standing here for two thousand three hundred years, in a tradition that was already centuries old when they were built.

I found the footprints of Chandragupta Maurya, the emperor who, according to tradition, abdicated his throne and came to this hill to end his life by the Jain practice of *sallekhana*: voluntary fasting unto death, the ultimate act of non-violence against the self, the final liberation from the body's claims. He is said to have sat in meditation here for twelve years before dying.

There is a cave on the hill where the great Jain acharya Bhadrabahu is said to have meditated. Inside it, the quality of the dark is specific. I sat in it for a moment, listening to the Karnataka afternoon outside.

I thought about what the Jain tradition was saying, taken as a whole. It was saying: the self you identify with is not your real self. The reactions that feel most instinctive and most yours (the anger, the hunger, the desire for recognition, the reflexive grasping) are not you. They are the film you have been watching so long that you have confused it with the projection. Your real nature is something much stiller, much purer, much less invested in the outcome of what is happening on the screen.

It was saying: every living thing you encounter, human, animal, insect, plant, is another such observer, equally real, equally trapped in its own film. The violence you do to any of them is a violence done to something of the same fundamental nature as yourself.

And it was saying (through anekantavada, through the humility it builds into its epistemology) that it does not know everything, and knows that it does not know everything. That the other traditions have also seen things. That the appropriate response to encountering a different perspective on reality is not refutation but the careful question: what part of the elephant are you touching?

Bahubali stood on his hill, the vines climbing his ankles, the ants building their hills to his shins, the serpents coiled at his feet. A thousand years of Karnataka monsoons have washed over him. Armies have moved through the valley below. Empires have risen and collapsed. He has not moved. His expression has not changed.

It is the face of someone who has understood something that ordinary consciousness cannot contain, and who is not in any hurry to explain it. The explanation is the standing there. The standing there is the explanation.

I climbed back down the six hundred steps into the ordinary afternoon.

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# Chapter Four

## *A Family of Experiments: Encountering Christianity*

> *Is it not curious that the same word should be used for the faith of a Quaker and a Crusader, a liberation theologian and an Inquisitor?*
>
> — *personal notes, Manchester, 2008*

### I. The Problem of the Name

Ramakrishna practiced Christianity for a period and saw Jesus. This is, by any reasonable account, a remarkable claim. But before asking whether it is true, it is worth asking what exactly he practiced. Which Christianity? The question is not pedantic.

The word covers too much to be a useful unit of analysis. A Quaker sitting in total silence for an hour in a plain room in Manchester, a Pentecostal congregation speaking in tongues until the walls vibrate, a Jesuit priest guiding a retreatant through Ignatius's exercises in a country house, a Mormon elder sitting in someone's flat in Wythenshawe explaining that divine authority was lost from the earth for seventeen centuries and has now been restored, all of these people call themselves Christians. They are not, in any obvious sense, doing the same

thing. To say you have encountered Christianity is a bit like saying you have tasted food. The category is true. It carries almost no information.

What Ramakrishna encountered, by his own account, was a meditative encounter with the figure of Christ: he sat with Christian devotees, read the Bible, and concentrated on the person of Jesus with the same absorbed intensity he brought to Kali, to Krishna, to Allah. He was not evaluating denominations. He was doing what he always did, trying to find out, from the inside, what a tradition actually offered at depth. He went straight to the experiential core and came back with a report.

I could not do this. I arrived in Manchester in 2002 with Christian hymns already in the furniture of my mind, ten years in a Catholic school in Lucknow had installed them, but with no practice tradition and no living community. What I had, instead, was access to an extraordinary variety of Christian expressions in a single city, and five years in which to sit with them. This chapter is my best attempt to distil what I found across those five years into what is relevant to the Ramakrishna question: not a survey of denominations, but an account of what different Christian communities actually do to the person inside them, and whether any of it points at what Ramakrishna said he found.

## II. The Body: A Pentecostal Church

The first thing a visitor notices, walking into a Pentecostal service, is the sound. Not music exactly, something closer to a pressure. Dozens of voices raised simultaneously, each in its own address to the same God, the cumulative noise rising and falling like a tide. Inside, people stand with eyes closed and palms upturned, shouting praises to the Lord. Some are speaking in tongues: syllables that follow the rhythm of intense speech but belong to no identifiable language.

I attended a Nigerian-founded Pentecostal fellowship in Manchester, and then later a South Asian Pentecostal church called the Universal Pentecostal Church, for several years combined. What both traditions share, whatever their theological differences, is a complete conviction that the body is the medium of encounter with God. The raised hands, the loud praise, the speaking in tongues, these are not decorations. They are the technology. The point is to create, through sustained collective physical and vocal engagement, conditions in which the Spirit can move. And the Spirit, in this framework, is not a metaphor. It is a presence that can be felt, that has effects, that responds.

There is something that happens in these rooms that is not nothing. I want to be careful about how I describe this, because the ease of dismissal is great and the honest account is more complicated. Standing in a room where a hundred people are praising God with their whole bodies, the sound at a volume that

makes ordinary thought difficult, the collective energy directed toward a single invisible presence, something happens to the individual standing inside it. Ordinary consciousness is disrupted. Something else becomes available, or becomes noticeable. I found it uncomfortable and genuine at the same time, which is perhaps the most honest description possible.

In early 2003, at an invitation during a service, I made a public prayer of commitment. Something shifted in those minutes. I have spent twenty years trying to understand what exactly shifted, and I cannot give a complete account. What I can say is that the experience was real and that the conditions that produced it were also real, a sustained practice of collective bodily and vocal orientation toward the divine, refined over decades by people who had discovered through experience what worked. Ramakrishna, who practiced Islam with full physical and dietary observance, who allowed each path to define the field of his experience rather than approaching it intellectually, would have recognized this method even if the content was foreign to him.

The UPC's theology of perfection (the belief that salvation is only the beginning, that holiness requires continuous surrender and effort, that the Christian life is an ongoing project rather than a settled condition) has a parallel in every deep spiritual tradition I encountered. The Jain understanding that karma must be steadily burned away through purification; the

Buddhist sense of the path as a long cultivation rather than a single event; even Ramakrishna's own endless longing rather than comfortable arrival. The UPC's demand is total. It organises the body, the week, the social life, the understanding of death. Whether what it produces at depth is the same presence Ramakrishna reported finding through Kali and Islam is the question I cannot answer. But that it produces something (something that requires the body's full participation) I have no doubt.

## III. The Question: An Anglican Chaplaincy

The chaplaincy at St Peter's in Manchester operated on the opposite principle from the Pentecostal church. Where the UPC asked for total commitment before anything else could happen, the chaplaincy asked for almost nothing. You arrived. You sat down. You were given food. You were welcomed as you were, with all your doubts still intact, and the doubts were not treated as problems to be solved but as the appropriate starting point for people in the most intellectually restless phase of their lives.

The KISS service, Keep It Simple, Sunday, met on Sunday evenings with between six and twenty people. No fixed order. No required creed. On one evening a chaplain led a Bible study on the Hebrew structure of the Lord's Prayer. On another, the congregation role-played the Palm Sunday story from four different perspectives simultaneously: Roman soldiers, Jesus's

followers, bystanders, Jewish priests watching from the temple. The point was explicit: each of us contains all four responses. On a third evening the Song of Solomon was discussed as possible scripture, and the chaplain admitted he was not entirely sure it belonged in the Bible.

The Maundy Thursday service set a Seder table with parsley dipped in salt water, unleavened bread, bitter herbs, charoset (making visible the Jewish roots of the Last Supper rather than absorbing them invisibly into ritual. The Taizé chant that ended the service)*Stay with me, remain here with me, watch and pray*. It was Jesus's request to his disciples in the garden. The congregation left without announcement, in silence, into the Manchester night.

What the Anglican chaplaincy primarily shapes is the capacity to hold a question open. Not to avoid commitment indefinitely, but to inhabit uncertainty honestly, without the anxiety of needing to resolve it immediately. This is a specific spiritual capacity, not a vague one. It requires training. The training involves taking the texts seriously, taking the questions seriously, and accepting that honest engagement with difficulty is itself a form of faithfulness.

For Ramakrishna's experiment, this matters. When he practiced Christianity, he was not reading Anglican theology. But the Anglican tradition's characteristic openness (its willingness to host the doubt, the question, the incomplete seeker)represents

something the tradition has learned across centuries of necessity. The Hilfield Franciscan retreat I attended, led by a former Church of England minister who described himself as a Buddhist Christian, was the most direct encounter I had with this quality at depth. Eight of us spent a weekend in a community that baked its own bread and kept chickens, doing guided meditation on the Passion in which each participant took the role of one of the figures present: Pilate, Mary, the soldiers, the crowd. I was assigned the role of Jesus. What happened during that exercise I will not describe precisely, except to say that it was not nothing and that it required the Anglican tradition's characteristic willingness to let experience be the teacher rather than doctrine.

## IV. The Imagination: The Jesuit Retreat

At Loyola House in Manchester, a Jesuit retreat centre, I attended a silent retreat over three days. The method was Ignatian: rather than emptying the mind in the Buddhist style, or offering praise in the Pentecostal style, or holding questions open in the Anglican style, the Ignatian exercises ask the retreatant to populate scenes from the Gospels with full sensory detail (smell the dust, feel the heat, hear the voices) until the doctrine becomes experience rather than proposition.

My spiritual director told me to stay with the feeling of peace and warmth when it came, and not to pay attention to the small

voice of scepticism saying *no*. He said: it doesn't matter if the text doesn't exactly tally with where your imagination leads you. If the feeling is real, it's not just imagination. Stay with it.

I have thought about this instruction ever since, because it maps precisely onto what Ramakrishna's teachers told him at Dakshineswar: go and worship the goddess. His initial resistance to image worship was overcome not by argument but by practice, by turning toward the stone with full sincerity until the stone appeared to breathe. The Jesuit retreat director's instruction had the same structure: trust the experience, not the scepticism. Work with what the practice gives you rather than with what the analytical mind is doing to the practice.

The Jesuit tradition cultivates the imagination as a serious spiritual instrument. This is unusual and undervalued in comparative religion discussions, which tend to focus on theology or ethics. But the imagination (the capacity to inhabit a story from the inside, to feel what the figures in it feel, to be affected by the narrative's logic) is, in the Ignatian system, the primary vehicle of encounter with the divine. It is not decoration. It is the method.

Whether Ramakrishna's visions of a luminous Christ figure were produced by something like this (an intense imaginative inhabiting of the Christian story until it came alive and had effects) is impossible to know. But the Ignatian exercises suggest that the tradition has its own understanding of how such things

happen, and has developed practices for producing the conditions under which they become possible.

## V. The Silence: The Quakers

The Friends Meeting House on Mount Street in Manchester has been in continuous use since the seventeenth century. On Sunday mornings a group of perhaps twenty people sits in silence for an hour. There is no minister. There are no prayers or hymns by default. If someone feels moved to speak, they do. Most Sundays include two or three brief contributions from members. Then the hour ends, hands are shaken, and the meeting is over.

I found Quaker silence both the most difficult and the most rewarding practice I encountered in these years. The difficulty is not the silence itself, anyone who has sat in Buddhist meditation is familiar with silence. The difficulty is the specific quality of the Quaker silence, which is not the silence of individual practice but of a gathered community attending together to the same invisible presence. The silence is not individual. It is shared. What is shared feels different from what is generated alone.

The Quaker tradition holds that there is an Inner Light in every person, directly accessible without intermediary, no priest, no sacrament, no creed. This is the most radical claim in all of Christianity: that the divine is not out there, being channelled

through authorised personnel, but in here, available to anyone who is willing to be still enough to notice it. The three and a half centuries the Quakers have spent testing this hypothesis have produced a community capable of remarkable clarity and occasionally frustrating indecisiveness, but also, at its best, of a quality of attention to each other and to the world that is different from what I found anywhere else.

For the Ramakrishna question, the Quaker silence raises the sharpest version of it: is what is available in that room the same presence Ramakrishna found in the Kali temple and the mosque? The Quakers would say yes, by definition (the Inner Light is universal. Ramakrishna would say yes, by experience) he found the same destination through every door. The question I cannot answer is whether they are right in the same way or right in different ways. But I sat in that room on Mount Street more than once, and whatever was available there was available, and it was not nothing.

## VI. What Ramakrishna Found

Ramakrishna's account of practicing Christianity is brief but specific. He meditated on the figure of Christ, sat with Christian devotees, read the Bible. And he had a vision of a luminous figure, radiant and compassionate, who merged into him.

None of the fourteen Christian communities I spent time with in Manchester offered me that. I do not think this is a failure of

the communities. I think it reflects the difference between Ramakrishna's method and mine, the difference he went deep and sequential, inhabiting each path until it temporarily displaced his previous frame, while I went broad and overlapping, always maintaining my position as a visitor rather than a participant.

But what I can say, after five years, is this: Christianity is not one thing. It is a family of experiments, each testing a different hypothesis about what human life looks like when organised around a particular understanding of God. The Pentecostal is testing: does total bodily surrender to the Spirit produce holiness? The Quaker is testing: does silent communal attention to the Inner Light produce wisdom and justice? The Jesuit is testing: does the trained imagination encounter the real? The Anglican is testing: does the honest holding of the question constitute faithfulness?

Each of these experiments has real results, visible in the people it produces. None of the results is the final verdict. And somewhere in the space between them (not in any single denomination but in what the whole family, taken together, has accumulated) there is something that Ramakrishna recognized and I believe he was right to recognize. That the figure of Christ, whatever he ultimately is, opens something in people. That the traditions built around him have developed, imperfectly and

sometimes horribly, genuine methods for encountering whatever he was pointing at.

He sits on my altar in Bangalore next to the Buddha and Shiva. The company feels natural rather than contradictory. The communities of this chapter would not all recognise the arrangement. But it is the honest position from which this chapter was written. None of these communities has given me everything. Between them, they have given me a great deal.

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# Chapter Five

## *The Name Is the Lord: Encountering ISKCON*

> *Chant and be happy. The best meditation is to chant the name of God, whether you call him Krishna or Allah or Christ. The name is the same.*
>
> — *a prabhu, Manchester ISKCON temple, 2010*

### I. The Bus from Manchester

The bus left the Manchester ISKCON centre on Mayfield Road at eight in the morning (we'd been told seven, but there were problems finding the right way to wrap the curries in cling film) and for several hours, driving south toward London, the devotees on board chanted. Three or four sessions of an hour each, to the accompaniment of kartals and mridanga drums, the maha-mantra filling the coach like weather: *Hare Krishna, Hare Krishna, Krishna Krishna, Hare Hare / Hare Rama, Hare Rama, Rama Rama, Hare Hare.*

I was on that bus. I had been going to the Manchester ISKCON temple for months. I had attended Bhagavad Gita classes every Friday evening, sitting on the floor in rows while a prabhu summarised chapter by chapter, supplementing with anecdotes and jokes and the particular texture of someone who had genuinely inhabited the material. I had chanted one round of the

maha-mantra on a set of 108 beads, which takes about eight minutes, and which is the minimum daily practice expected of devotees. I had accepted prasadam (the food offered first to Krishna and then distributed) with the understanding that accepting it has spiritual value independent of whether one believes this. I had attended Diwali celebrations, the Govardhan Puja, a Bhagavad Gita study day. I had been to the London Rath Yatra in that bus, and had danced down the street from Hyde Park to Trafalgar Square.

Of all the traditions I encountered during the Ramakrishna experiment, ISKCON (the International Society for Krishna Consciousness, the Hare Krishna movement) is the one I returned to most often and most consistently. This requires some explanation, because it is not, on the surface, the obvious choice for a Bengali Hindu from a Ramakrishna Mission background. The ISKCON theology is specific and demanding: Krishna is not one name among many for the divine, but the Supreme Personality of Godhead; the bhakti path of devotion to Krishna is not one path among several valid ones, but the path most suited to the present age of Kali; Srila Prabhupada, who brought the tradition to the West in 1966, is a spiritual authority of the highest order; the maha-mantra, chanted regularly, is not merely a meditation technique but a direct invocation of the divine name, which is held to be non-different from the divine itself.

These are specific claims. They are not universalist claims. ISKCON, more than any other tradition I encountered, would have the most vigorous argument with the *joto mot, toto path* principle, not because the tradition is closed-minded, but because it genuinely believes that some paths are more direct than others, and that the bhakti path in this age is the most direct of all.

And yet I kept going back. And yet the quality of what happened in those Friday evening classes was, again and again, something I found nowhere else. The question is why, and what it tells us about Ramakrishna's experiment.

## II. The Bhagavad Gita Classes

The Bhagavad Gita class at the Manchester ISKCON temple followed a consistent structure. First, some bhajans, devotional songs to Krishna and Rama, in Sanskrit and Hindi, accompanied by harmonium and mridanga. The room would fill gradually with devotees and visitors, sitting on the floor, some in traditional dress, some in ordinary clothes. The prabhu who led most of the classes was a resident monk, someone who had taken vows of celibacy and community life and had given up ordinary employment for full-time service to Krishna.

Then the class itself: the prabhu would take a chapter or a section of a chapter and work through it verse by verse, reading from Srila Prabhupada's translation and commentary,

supplementing with stories from the Puranas and from the lives of the Vaishnava saints, from the life of Prabhupada himself. The teaching was systematic (over eighteen weeks they covered all eighteen chapters) but it was never dry. The prabhu had a gift for the concrete example, the unexpected analogy, the joke that landed exactly when the philosophical density had become almost too much.

The Gita's central teaching, as presented in these classes, was radical in its implications: the body is not you. The individual self, the person who suffers, who fears death, who is attached to outcomes, is not the real self. The real self is the atman, the eternal soul, which is distinct from the body and mind and which passes from life to life according to karma. Death is not the end of the self but the end of a particular body. Understanding this not intellectually but experientially, actually knowing it, in the way you know your own face, is the beginning of real spiritual life.

Chapter two of the Gita contains the most compressed philosophical statement of this position, and the prabhu's treatment of it was memorable. Arjuna is at Kurukshetra, about to fight a war in which he will kill his own relatives. He drops his bow and refuses. Krishna's response is what the rest of the Gita elaborates: the soul is eternal, bodies come and go like old clothes, you are not killing anyone who can ultimately be killed, and your duty as a warrior must be performed without

attachment to the results. The teaching is addressed to Arjuna's confusion between his body-identification and his spiritual reality.

For Ramakrishna's experiment, this is directly relevant. The Advaita Vedanta of Shankara, which Ramakrishna also practiced, makes a similar claim about the identity of the individual self and the universal Self. The Gita's Vaishnavism makes a different version of it: the atman is real and eternal, but it is eternally distinct from the Supreme, not identical with Brahman, as Advaita holds, but in a relationship of devotional love with Krishna that constitutes its highest fulfilment. The difference between these two positions is philosophically serious and theologically significant. What they share is the foundational claim: ordinary consciousness is identified with something that is not its real nature.

## III. The Maha-Mantra

In the ISKCON framework, the maha-mantra is not primarily a meditation technique. It is a direct calling of the divine name, and the divine name is held to be non-different from the divine itself. Chanting *Hare Krishna* is not visualising Krishna or thinking about Krishna or reading about Krishna. It is calling Krishna. And Krishna, in this theology, hears.

I chanted on beads for the first time at a class where the prabhu handed out sets of 108 and walked us through the method: hold

the bead between thumb and middle finger, say the mantra once, move to the next bead, say the mantra again, until you reach the guru bead at the end of the round, then turn around and go back. The total is 108 repetitions. One round takes about eight to ten minutes. Advanced devotees chant sixteen rounds a day, roughly two hours. The minimum expected of those considering initiation is four rounds.

What chanting does to the person doing it depends, the tradition would say, on the quality of attention and surrender brought to it. Done mechanically, it clears the mind in the way any repeated mantra does. Done with genuine invocation, actually calling, actually attending, it has a different quality. I cannot claim to have done it with full genuine invocation. But I can report that chanting the maha-mantra on the bus from Manchester to London, surrounded by fifty devotees who were doing so with full genuine invocation, produced a different quality of experience than sitting alone with beads.

The collective dimension is important and often overlooked in discussions of mantra practice. The tradition understands *sankirtana*, the public chanting of God's names, as the primary spiritual practice recommended for the age of Kali. Not private meditation, not scriptural study, not yogic technique. The chanting of Krishna's names together, aloud, in the streets if possible, is what the tradition considers most efficacious and most appropriate to the current age. The Rath Yatra, the chariot

festival in which massive wooden carts bearing the images of Jagannath, Baladeva, and Subhadra are pulled through the streets by thousands of devotees, is the ultimate expression of this: devotion brought into the public square, the divine name offered to whoever can hear it.

I pulled a rope on one of the carts in Trafalgar Square. Whatever the theological status of the action, the phenomenology was unmistakable: a large crowd, a shared direction, a repetitive chant, a wooden cart of great mass moving slowly. Something happened in the pulling. Something was shared.

## IV. The Bhakti Quality

What is distinctive about the bhakti tradition (and this is the reason, I think, that I kept returning to ISKCON when I could have been attending other traditions) is the quality of love that it cultivates.

Every tradition I encountered has some form of love in it. The Christian traditions speak of love extensively. The Islamic tradition's *rahma*, compassion, is one of the two names of God recited at the start of every prayer. The Bahai faith is explicitly organised around the principle of universal love. The Jain tradition's non-violence arises from a recognition of the equal value and sanctity of all life.

But the bhakti path cultivates a very specific form of love: personal, relational, devotional, and directed toward a named divine figure who is understood to love in return. This is different from the abstract love of universal principles. The devotee does not love the idea of the divine. They love *Krishna*: a specific, named, described, narratively rich being, whose stories fill the Puranas and the Mahabharata and the Bhagavata, whose flute music draws the cowherd girls into the forest at midnight, whose conversation with Arjuna at Kurukshetra is the Gita. The love has an object. The object responds.

The prabhu who led the classes once said something that I wrote down: *We cannot appreciate all the benefits of chanting the name immediately. The name of Lord is same as Lord himself. Its so easy. Just need to move lips and chant*. This is the bhakti claim in its simplest form: the divine is not distant, requiring years of purification before approach. The divine is available now, through the name, to whoever calls with sincerity. The requirement is not achievement but orientation, turning toward Krishna rather than away.

This is recognizably related to what the Pentecostal church offers through praise, and to what the Quaker meeting offers through silence, and to what the Sufi orders offer through *dhikr*, the practice of dhikr, the remembrance of the divine name. Each tradition has found, through a different cultural and theological path, something similar: that sustained, sincere, repetitive

attention to the divine (in whatever form the tradition has developed for holding that attention) produces effects.

Whether these effects are the same effect is the question Ramakrishna's experiment was designed to answer. I cannot answer it. What I can say is that the bhakti quality (the warm, personal, relational, love-saturated quality of the ISKCON devotional atmosphere) was something I did not find in the same form anywhere else, and that the absence of it, when I was not in those rooms, was noticeable. Something was available there that my own tradition, for all its richness, had not quite given me.

## V. The Demand

ISKCON, like every tradition encountered in this experiment, makes a demand. The demand is not doctrinal assent, you are not required to believe the full theology before attending a class. The demand is something more subtle: that you bring your full attention. That you not treat the maha-mantra as background music. That you not consume the prasadam as a free meal. That you not attend the Gita class as a cultural tourism experience.

The tradition is alert to the superficial visitor, not hostilely but clearly. The question asked (gently, by the prabhu, over prasadam after the class) is always some version of: are you practising? Not: do you believe? Not: have you been initiated?

But: are you actually doing something with what you have received?

I was always partially honest in my answer. I was chanting, occasionally. I was attending, regularly. I was not practising in the full sense the tradition intends, which would require a sustained daily commitment to the maha-mantra, a relationship with a guru, a reorganisation of my life around service to Krishna. I was, as I had been in every tradition in this experiment, a genuine but partial visitor.

The tradition's response to this was generous: you are welcome here. Come as often as you like. Take what is given. But it always carried an implicit: *and if you wanted to go further, here is the door*. The door was always open. I never walked through it. This is, perhaps, the most honest summary of the ISKCON chapter of this experiment: a door I stood at for years, receiving the warmth from the fire inside, not willing to step in fully but not willing to leave.

## VI. Ramakrishna and Bhakti

Ramakrishna was, before everything else, a devotee of Kali. His entire spiritual life grew from a Kali temple, from the specific devotional relationship with the goddess that he entered as a young priest and never left. When he practiced Islam, when he practiced Christianity, when he sat with Advaitins and Vaishnavas and Shaktas, he was not abandoning bhakti, he was

finding it everywhere. The *joto mot, toto path* principle is, in Ramakrishna's hands, not a philosophical proposition about the equality of paths. It is a devotee's discovery that the beloved can be found by every route.

ISKCON understands this, actually, or at least, the tradition's most generous interpreters do. The prabhu who once said *whether we call him Krishna or Allah or Christ, the name is the same* was not making a universalist claim that the tradition's theology would not fully support. He was making the devotee's claim: that sincere calling reaches. That turning toward reaches. That the name (any name spoken with full longing) goes somewhere.

Whether all names go to the same somewhere is the question I cannot answer. What I can say is that the ISKCON temple in Manchester, on a Friday evening with the class ending and the prasadam being brought out, the prabhu making announcements about the Rath Yatra in Piccadilly on Sunday and the bhajan CD available for five pounds by the door, that room was closer to what Ramakrishna described than almost anywhere else I went. Something in the bhakti quality, something in the warmth and the music and the specific texture of devotional love, pointed at the same direction he was pointing.

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# Chapter Six

## *The Langar and the Kirtan: Encountering Sikhism*

> *One door leads inside. Another leads to food. Both are the same door.*

### I. The Floor

The first thing you notice is that everyone sits on the floor. There is a specific quality to a space where the floor is the intended place, not a temporary accommodation or a concession to numbers, but the design. The floor is where you are supposed to be. There are no chairs. There are no reserved seats. There is no front. The carpet stretches from one end of the room to the other, and on it, in rows, people sit cross-legged in varying degrees of comfort and competence, from the very old who have been sitting this way since childhood and fold into it without thinking, to the very young who fidget, to visitors like myself who discover, twenty minutes in, that there is a joint they had not previously located that is now the only thing they can think about.

I attended a Sikh gurdwara for the first time on a Saturday morning in Manchester, and I remember the quality of the light: pale and still, coming through frosted windows, softening

everything. The room smelled of incense and something warm and faintly sweet that I later identified as the prasad being prepared in the kitchen below. The harmonium was already playing. A man with a white turban and a white beard sat at the front, not elevated on a stage but simply there, the Guru Granth Sahib open on a low cushioned stand before him. He was reading, or singing, or both; the two were not separable. The Gurbani, the hymns of the Guru Granth Sahib, are not texts that happen to be set to music. They are music that happens to carry a text. They arrived that way, composed by the Gurus and by the saints whose contributions the fifth Guru, Arjan Dev, gathered into the compilation, and they were always intended to be heard.

I did not understand the Punjabi. This turned out to matter less than I had expected, because what Gurbani communicates is not entirely contained in its literal meaning. Something in the melodic structures — the ragas the hymns are assigned to, each one associated with a different time of day, a different emotional register, a different quality of devotional attention — enters the body before the intellect has a chance to process it. I sat on the floor with my back not quite straight enough and let the sound do what it was evidently designed to do.

## II. Ik Onkar

At the opening of the Guru Granth Sahib is a single phrase: Ik Onkar. One God. One reality. Everything that follows — the hymns of Guru Nanak, Guru Angad, Guru Amar Das, Guru Ram Das, Guru Arjan Dev, Guru Tegh Bahadur, and the

contributions of saints from outside the Sikh tradition entirely, the Muslim weaver Kabir and the low-caste poet Ravidas and the Brahmin Jaidev — all of it flows from this single affirmation. The multiplicity of voices, the variety of perspectives and metaphors and devotional approaches, is held within a single recognition that there is one reality behind all of them.

This is not philosophically unusual. Many traditions make this claim. What is unusual is what the Sikh tradition does with it structurally. The Guru Granth Sahib contains the voices of Hindus and Muslims and people from multiple castes. It was compiled by a Guru who understood that different human beings reach toward the same divine through different sensibilities, and that the scripture of a tradition should contain that diversity rather than flatten it. The text itself enacts the teaching. If you open it anywhere, you may find a couplet by Kabir, who spoke in the language of the north Indian weaving community, or a hymn by Guru Nanak that begins with the pre-dawn meditation called Japji Sahib, which Sikhs recite every morning as the first act of the day.

In the Ramakrishna Mission bookshop in Lucknow, as a student, I had read Ramakrishna's accounts of his encounters with different traditions. His exploration of Sikhism is not extensively documented in The Gospel, but the principle that animated his method was exactly what I was now watching being enacted in practice: that the same One can be approached from anywhere, and that whoever approaches with

full sincerity will arrive at the same place, expressed in a different tongue.

### III. The Sangat

Sangat is the Punjabi word for the congregation, but it carries a weight that the English word does not. It comes from the Sanskrit sangha, company, and it refers not merely to the people present in the gurdwara at a given time but to the quality of being together that is itself considered a spiritual practice. To sit in sangat — in the presence of the Guru Granth Sahib, with other people who are also in that presence — is not a preparation for something else. It is the thing itself. The act of gathering, of choosing to be in this room with these people in the hearing of these words, is understood as spiritually transforming in a way that cannot be reduced to the sum of its individual components. You cannot have exactly the same experience alone at home, even with the same recording, the same text, the same interior preparation. The sangat adds something.

I had read about this in one of the pamphlets the gurdwara made available for visitors. What struck me was the claim's modesty. It did not say: the sangat transforms you through mysterious grace. It said, more simply: the company of people who are seriously attempting something has an effect on others who are attempting the same thing. Something passes between human beings in serious mutual attention that does not pass between a human being and a book, however good the book. This seemed to me demonstrably true. I had felt it in the Hare

Krishna temple when the kirtan lifted the room. I had felt it in the UPC church in Liverpool when the praise went from participation to something else. I had felt it in the silence of the Jain temple when the collective stillness became more than the sum of individual stillnesses. The sangat is the Sikh name for a phenomenon that every tradition seems to know.

**IV. The Langar**

After the service, the congregation moved downstairs.

The langar is the communal kitchen and the communal meal that the gurdwara provides free to anyone who comes, regardless of religion, caste, income, or status. It was instituted by Guru Nanak himself as a direct challenge to the caste system: if you eat from the same pot, in the same room, sitting at the same level as everyone else, the hierarchies that organise ordinary social life are, for that hour, suspended.

I sat on the floor again, this time on a mat that ran the length of the room. Beside me was an elderly Sikh man who had been in Manchester since the 1960s; across from me was a Pakistani Muslim family who came every week specifically for the langar; further down, a group of students who had wandered in from the street. Volunteers moved along the rows with large metal pots, serving dal and roti and a sweet kheer. You held out your plate. They served you. You ate. The whole arrangement communicated something so directly that it barely needed to be stated: you are hungry, we have food, sit down.

I had by this point attended enough interfaith events to be familiar with the formal register of such occasions: the

speeches about the importance of tolerance, the ceremonial sharing of symbolic food, the posed photograph of religious leaders standing together. The langar was not this. It was not a demonstration of tolerance. It was simply food. The theological statement it made was made through the act of making lunch and offering it to whoever arrived. The caste system, which had for centuries sorted human beings into hierarchies of ritual purity and pollution, determined who could eat with whom and from what vessel — the langar's answer to this was not a counter-argument but a counter-practice. Don't argue about equality. Cook rice. Feed people. Make sure the pot is large enough.

Guru Nanak had said, in the Japji Sahib: Pavan guru, pani pita, mata dharat mahat. Air is the Guru, water is the Father, the great earth is the Mother. The physical world is not the obstacle to spirituality. It is where spirituality happens. The body that needs feeding is not a distraction from the soul. The soul is, in some sense, the body's capacity to recognise other bodies as deserving food.

## V. Equality and the Absent Priesthood

There is no ordained priesthood in Sikhism.

The granthi, the person who reads and leads the service, is not a priest in any sacramental sense. He or she is someone trained to read the Guru Granth Sahib, to perform the rites, to lead the congregation. But anyone may do this. The role is not exclusive, not hereditary, not conferring special ontological status. The Guru Granth Sahib itself is the Guru. After the

tenth human Guru, Gobind Singh, declared that he would have no successor in human form, the scripture became the living Guru of the tradition. It is treated as such: carried in procession, put to sleep and woken, fanned during services with a fly-whisk, covered when not in use. This is not metaphor. It is the tradition's institutional encoding of the recognition that no human being should occupy the position of necessary mediator between another human being and the divine.

I had been thinking, by this point in my experiment, about the recurring tension in every tradition I had encountered between the form and the reality it pointed at; between the container and the water. The Jains had put it most starkly: the liberated souls are beyond attributes, beyond assistance, beyond the reach of prayer. You cannot petition them; you can only use their example as a lamp to walk by. The structure of the Jain temple exists, paradoxically, to point toward a reality that is not reachable through the temple. The Sikhs had solved the same problem differently. By making the scripture the Guru, they had placed the mediation in a text rather than a person. The text is open; the text is the same for everyone; the text is, in principle, available to any literate Punjabi speaker. The hierarchy collapses into the page.

Whether this is a solution or a different kind of problem is a question the tradition has been working through for three hundred and fifty years. But the attempt itself reflects the same intuition I had been noticing across traditions: that the reality they are all pointing at resists being owned. Every tradition

that claims exclusive access to the divine is making a claim that the divine, in its own self-presentation, consistently refuses to endorse.

## VI. Waheguru

The name most often used for God in Sikhism is Waheguru, which is variously translated as Wonderful Lord, or Wondrous Enlightener, and which is used both as a name and as a mantra. Sikhs repeat it under their breath as they walk, as they work, as they fall asleep. It is intended to become, over time, the ground-note of consciousness, the presence that underlies the particular thoughts passing through.

At the music of the faiths banquet at St Peter's Chaplaincy, where I sat through nine traditions performing in sequence in a single evening, the Sikh group came in the middle. Two men with turbans, a harmonium, a tabla. They sat on the floor, as is the practice, and began. What they brought was different from the devotional exuberance of the Hare Krishna maha-mantra that came later, and different again from the sustained interior silence of the Korean Zen Heart Sutra chant. It had a quality I want to call steady. Not the ecstatic upswing of bhakti, not the dissolving inwardness of meditation, but something that moved at walking pace through a landscape it knew well.

The kirtan seemed to me to embody the quality the tradition calls Sahaj: an equanimity that is not the result of suppressing emotion but of having gone through emotion and arrived at something on the other side of it. The calm not of someone who has never been disturbed but of someone who has been

thoroughly disturbed and is no longer afraid of disturbance. I do not know whether I understood this at the time or whether I am imposing a retrospective pattern. But I remember that when the kirtan ended, the room was different than when it had begun. Not reduced to silence, not raised to exuberance, but settled. The way a room feels after someone very calm has sat in it for a long time.

## VII. What Guru Nanak Saw

Guru Nanak, the tradition's founder, was born in 1469 in the Punjab region that is now Pakistan. He grew up in a context defined by the tension between Hindu and Muslim ways of life, and what he said about that tension was this: Na koi Hindu, na koi Mussalman. There is neither Hindu nor Muslim. He meant: at the level that matters, these categories do not describe the reality of what is happening. The Hindu path and the Muslim path are both paths toward the same reality. The names on the door do not describe what is inside.

This is precisely what Ramakrishna said four centuries later, in Bengal, in a different language and from within the Hindu tradition. Both arrived at the same place by different routes: Guru Nanak by a direct apprehension that the categories he had been handed did not describe the territory; Ramakrishna by practice, by entering each tradition completely enough to find what it contained, and finding the same thing.

I am not saying the two are identical. The Sikh tradition developed very specifically in response to a specific historical context, the pressures of Mughal rule, the caste system, the

encounter between Hinduism and Islam on the Punjab plain. Ramakrishna worked within a different context entirely, the Bengal of the nineteenth century, the encounter between Hinduism and Western modernity, the particular problems that his time and place had generated. The similarities in conclusion do not erase the differences in path.

But the similarities are real, and they are worth sitting with on the floor of a Manchester gurdwara while the harmonium plays and the dal is being prepared downstairs. Every tradition I encountered in this experiment had its own specific gravity, its own texture, its own way of pressing on the same questions. The Sikh tradition pressed on the question of equality — not as a political aspiration but as a theological claim — with a directness I had not found anywhere else. If the One is the only reality, then all who carry that reality are equal. The langar is the proof. The Guru Granth Sahib as the living Guru is the proof. The absence of the ordained priest is the proof. The egalitarianism is not grafted onto the theology. It grows from it, the way a river grows from its source.

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# Chapter Seven

## *The Light on the Hedge: Encountering Judaism*

> *The menorah does not light the world. It lights the space beside the door.*

### I. The Skull Cap

A security officer at the entrance to the synagogue handed me a small navy-blue kippah. He explained, briefly and without condescension, that the head is covered as a sign that something is above it: an acknowledgement of the presence overhead, a gesture of the body that says, before any words are spoken, I am not the highest thing here. I pressed the fabric to my hair with what I hoped was adequate seriousness and followed the others inside.

It was the fourth night of Hanukkah. The synagogue was a Reform congregation in Manchester's city centre, housed in a building with no particular claim to grandeur from the outside. Inside, it was warm and filled with a congregation that seemed genuinely pleased to have visitors. The rabbi, a slight and energetic man with a knack for the precisely chosen phrase, was already explaining Hanukkah to the newcomers before the service began.

The story, he said, is about this: a temple was desecrated, a people tried to return to themselves, and there was only

enough oil to last for one day, but it lasted for eight. The miracle is not the military victory. That is not the miracle the holiday is really about. The miracle is the oil. The miracle is the impossible sufficiency: that what you have will be enough, against every rational expectation, to outlast the darkness.
Then he lit the candles. Four of them, one for each night elapsed, plus the shamash, the helper candle used to light the others, which stands slightly apart from the rest. The candles are not for study, he said. Not for reading, not for household work. They are placed by the door, or in the window, to be seen from outside. Their only purpose is to be looked at. Pirsumei nisa: the publicising of the miracle. The candles are the announcement.
I had been thinking, by this point in my experiment, a great deal about visibility. About what it means for a tradition to claim that the divine makes itself available to human attention, and what form that availability takes. The Bahai faith builds temples that are open to everyone, that have no fixed form of worship, so that each visitor brings their own prayer. The ISKCON temple in Manchester produced an abundance of devotional energy, a public exuberance, a procession that stopped traffic. The Hanukkah candles were simpler. They were placed beside the door, turned outward, to tell the person on the street that something was happening inside. The light is the testimony. The light says: we are still here.

## II. What Hanukkah Is About

The historical event being commemorated in Hanukkah is the Maccabean revolt of the second century BCE: a Jewish uprising against the Hellenistic ruler Antiochus IV Epiphanes, who had prohibited Jewish practice and desecrated the Temple in Jerusalem by erecting a statue of Zeus in it and ordering pigs sacrificed on the altar. The revolt succeeded. The Temple was rededicated. The menorah was lit.

The rabbi was careful to say: Hanukkah is not the most significant holiday in the Jewish calendar. Yom Kippur is. Passover is. Rosh Hashanah and Shavuot and Sukkot are. Hanukkah is, in terms of religious law, a relatively minor festival. It became prominent, he suggested, partly because of its proximity on the calendar to Christmas, which gave it a visibility in the diaspora that it might not otherwise have acquired.

But the reason he had given it this careful framing was precisely to say something more important. The Maccabean story is, in part, a story about the temptation of assimilation. Antiochus IV did not arrive in Jerusalem as an obvious enemy. He arrived as the representative of a sophisticated, appealing, widely admired civilisation that had already attracted many Jews who saw in Greek culture an exciting universalism that seemed, on the surface, not incompatible with Jewish values. The pressure was not only the pressure of persecution. It was also the pressure of attraction: the invitation to dissolve a particular identity into a more comfortable, more cosmopolitan, more universally legible one.

The Maccabees, on this reading, fought not only against desecration but against dissolution. Their victory was not only military. It was the refusal to disappear.

I had been thinking about this already, because I had been thinking about the problem of the experiment I was running. The Ramakrishna model assumes that traditions are like doors into the same room, that what matters is not which door you use but that you enter with sufficient sincerity. This is a generous and in many ways an illuminating model. But it carries a risk. If every path leads to the same place, then the particular features of any given path begin to look like accidents of culture, costume changes rather than substantive differences, and the pressure to abandon them in favour of something more universally legible increases. What the rabbi was describing, without quite framing it in those terms, was a tradition that had thought about this problem for two millennia.

Jewish particularism is not an accident or a limitation. It is, in the tradition's own understanding, the vehicle of a universal truth. The specific practices, the specific calendar, the specific language of prayer, the specific dietary laws and ritual observances, are not pre-philosophical ornaments on a universal philosophical core. They are the form through which a community has sustained, transmitted, and deepened a relationship with the divine across forty centuries of dispersal, persecution, and transformation. To dissolve the particular into the universal is not to discover the universal. It is to lose access to one specific way of holding it.

## III. The Service

The prayer book was laid out in three columns: the Hebrew on the right, the transliteration in the middle, and the English meaning on the left. The pages ran from right to left, so that if you were accustomed to opening a book from what you assumed was the front, you were starting at the back. The instruction to pause and reorient is built into the structure of the object.

I want to be honest about my experience of the service: I could not follow most of it, and the parts I could follow, I could follow only through the English translation, which is always a reading of a reading, the interpretation of a text that was composed in Hebrew, shaped over centuries in Aramaic commentary and Greek diaspora and Babylonian exile and mediaeval Andalusian poetry and Central European melody, arriving in an English Manchester evening through a process of transmission so long and complex that the translation can only gesture at what it carries.

And yet something came through. The first prayer we recited, the Shema Yisrael, is six words: Hear, O Israel: the Lord is our God, the Lord is One. The rabbi asked us to cover our eyes when we said it. This, he explained, is not merely to focus attention, though it does that. It is to make a specific internal movement: for the duration of the words, to attempt to mean them completely, to let the assertion that the Lord is One be not a doctrinal position but a direct perception, as immediate

as sight. You close your eyes to the multiplicity of the visible world in order to recognise, even briefly, the unity beneath it.
I had covered my eyes and said the words with the congregation. The Hebrew Echad, One, was drawn out at the end, held for what felt like a long breath, as if the word needed time to do what it was claiming. The room became very still.
Ramakrishna had said: Brahman is one without a second. Guru Nanak had said: Ik Onkar. The Sufi tradition had said: La ilaha illallah. The Shema said: Adonai Echad. Different words for the same insistence. What they share is not a theological proposition. It is an instruction about perception: look until you can see the unity, not as an idea overlaid on the diversity, but as the actual structure of what is there.

## IV. The Particular and the Universal

Candles lit from a single shamash. Eight nights, eight lights, one helper, one ongoing act of remembrance.
The rabbi said something that I have been returning to since. The menorah is traditionally placed not at the centre of the house but at the edge: by the door, or in the window. Its position is liminal, at the boundary between inside and outside, between the private space of the family and the public space of the street. The light is not for the household's illumination. It is pirsumei nisa, witness to the miracle, directed outward.
This is not a universal spirituality. It is a testimony, made in specific Hebrew words, on specific dates, by specific people whose ancestors stood at Sinai. The particularity is not

incidental. It is what makes the testimony possible. A universalised sentiment about the persistence of light is not the same thing as a community placing a menorah in a window on the fourth night of Hanukkah because their grandparents and their grandparents' grandparents did the same. The first is an idea. The second is a living transmission, a chain of memory and practice that runs backward through every Jewish community that has sat in a winter darkness and lit oil or candles and said: we are still here, and what we carry is still real.

I understood, sitting in that Manchester synagogue, something I had not understood when I began the experiment. Ramakrishna's insight, joto mot, toto path, is not an invitation to extract the universal and discard the particular. The paths are paths because they are specific. The water of the Ganges that Ramakrishna used as one of his favourite images does not flow anywhere if the riverbed is removed. The universalism he was pointing at is not the dry theoretical claim that all religions agree. It is the wet empirical observation that people who take any of these specific paths far enough, with enough seriousness, arrive at a quality of encounter that the different traditions describe in different languages but recognise in each other. The languages are not the same. The paths are not the same. But what is encountered at the far end of them has, across the reports of the people who have gone there, a family resemblance.

The candles by the door were telling the street: this has not ended.

## V. Shabbat

At the end of the Hanukkah service, the congregation moved into the smaller hall for the breaking of bread, the brief ceremony that precedes the Friday evening meal. The Shabbat was beginning. Someone had brought two braided loaves of challah, covered in a cloth. The rabbi said a blessing over the wine. The cloth was removed from the challah. The loaves were broken and passed around.

There was a moment before the cloth was removed that I want to try to describe. The loaves had been sitting there throughout the latter part of the service, under their cloth, present but not yet visible. The covering and uncovering had a logic: the challah is covered during the kiddush, the blessing over the wine, so that it does not feel passed over, does not have to witness the wine being blessed first. It sounds like anthropomorphism. It sounds like the kind of thing that stops making sense the moment you put it in cold prose. But in practice, in that room, the covered bread sat there with a patient quality, as if whatever was inside the cloth was waiting for the right moment. And when the cloth came off, the two loaves braided together, golden and soft, the room let out a small collective sound that was not quite a sigh and not quite a word.

I was thinking of the langar in the gurdwara downstairs from the previous week, the dal and the roti passed along the rows. I was thinking of the Hare Krishna prasad after the Sunday feast, the food that had been offered to the deity before being

offered to the congregation, so that it arrived at your plate already consecrated. I was thinking of the bread and wine at St Peter's Chaplaincy on Maundy Thursday, where the words over the cup were the words from the last supper, and the intention was that something was transmitted through the act of eating together that could not be transmitted any other way.

Every tradition I had entered had fed me. Not always literally, though often literally. But the act of eating together, of sharing food that had been prepared with intention and offered with generosity, kept appearing across every tradition as if the body's need for nourishment and the spirit's need for connection could not, at some deep level, be kept separate. You cannot feed one without attending to the other.

## VI. The Question of Chosenness

There is a theological concept in Judaism that I had been thinking about since before I visited the synagogue, and that I finally had an opportunity to ask about during the informal conversation after the service. The concept of the Jewish people as a chosen people is one that generates, from outside the tradition, everything from reverence to suspicion to misunderstanding, and from inside it, centuries of commentary and debate.

A woman who had grown up in the congregation and who had, she said, been thinking about the question since she was a child, offered me the version that she found most useful. The chosenness, she said, is not about superiority. It is about responsibility. The people who were at Sinai, in whatever sense

one reads that event, accepted an obligation: to bear a particular witness to the One in a particular way. Other people, other traditions, have their own covenants, their own forms of witness. The Jewish covenant is specific and demanding and non-transferable. That is not a boast. That is a weight.

I thought of the Sikh Khalsa, the community of initiated Sikhs who maintain the five Kakaars, the outward markers of their commitment — the unshorn hair, the steel bangle, the wooden comb, the cotton undergarment, the steel sword. Wherever you are, whatever country or context or professional setting, these five things announce: I am here, I am this, I have not dissolved into the background. Like the menorah in the window. Like the challah under the cloth. The visible particular as the vehicle of the non-visible universal.

There is a risk in this. The particular can harden into the merely parochial, into the claim that one's own form of witness is not one witness among others but the only witness worth having. This has happened in Judaism, in Sikhism, in every tradition I visited, because it is not a risk specific to any tradition. It is a risk specific to the human tendency to confuse the vehicle with what it carries. But the alternative — the dissolution of the particular into a comfortable universalism that carries no weight and demands no loyalty — is not an escape from this risk. It is a different failure, the failure of the shamash candle that gives light but does not itself stand in the row, does not itself commit to the particular position, the particular number, the particular night.

## VII. The Eight Nights

I went back on the final night of Hanukkah, when all eight candles were lit.

The menorah, fully lit, produces a quantity of light that the individual candles, night by night, only approximate. On the first night you have one flame. On the eighth, you have eight. The progression is the point. The practice does not begin with the full light. It begins in near-darkness and moves, one night at a time, toward the full illumination, which only comes at the end. You have to go through the diminished nights to get there.

This seemed to me, sitting in the synagogue on the eighth night while the rabbi spoke and the candles burned, to be a description of the experiment I had been running. The experiment does not begin with the full understanding. It begins with a question, a tentative movement toward a tradition that is not your own, a sitting on an unfamiliar floor, a covering of eyes over unfamiliar words. It proceeds, one encounter at a time, adding each new flame to the row, never quite arriving at the full light but approaching it incrementally, night by night.

And perhaps that is what there is. Perhaps the full eight flames is not a state of completion but a description of a process: the process of going through each tradition with enough seriousness to let it change something, of adding each new understanding to the row without extinguishing the ones already burning.

The menorah is not placed at the centre of the room, where it would illuminate the whole interior. It is placed at the edge,

turned toward the street, pointed outward. The light is not for you alone. The miracle is not for private consumption. The eight flames, fully lit, are turned toward whatever darkness lies beyond the window.

Na koi Hindu, na koi Mussalman, Guru Nanak had said. There is neither Hindu nor Muslim. And the rabbi had said: you do not have to be Jewish to light a candle for what you believe to be true. You only have to be willing to stand by the window.

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# Chapter Eight

## *The World as It Is: The Political Left as Structural Self-Enquiry*

> *Philosophers have only interpreted the world. The point is to change it.*
>
> *— Karl Marx, Theses on Feuerbach, 1845*

### I. The Two Directions

When Ramakrishna turned his attention inward, he asked: what is the nature of the self? What is this "I" that suffers and longs and fears? He pursued this question through every available door (Kali worship, Tantric practice, Advaita non-dual enquiry, Islam, Christianity) and reported finding the same luminous presence through each. His experiment was

one of the great systematic enquiries into the interior life in the history of human consciousness.

But there is another direction of self-enquiry. Not inward, toward the contents of consciousness. Outward, toward the structures that shape the conditions of conscious life. When this enquiry is pursued with the same seriousness, different questions emerge. Not what is the nature of the "I" that suffers, but who constructed the conditions in which this suffering exists. Not how do I transcend the world, but why is the world arranged as it is, and who benefits from the arrangement. Not what is the self, but what has been done to the self (what has been put inside it, presented as natural, as given, as the way things simply are) that in fact serves someone else's interest? This is the enquiry that the political left, in its most serious forms, has been conducting since at least the mid-nineteenth century. It belongs in this book, not because it is secretly a spiritual path, not because it leads to mystical union, but because it is the outward-facing pole of the impulse that drives every inward-facing tradition in these pages: the refusal to accept the inherited account of reality, and the effort to find out what is actually there.

I attended meetings of the British far left between 2007 and 2012, in Manchester and in Bangalore, not primarily as an exercise in political education, though some education resulted. I attended them because I had committed to following any serious path of enquiry into the nature of suffering and its causes, and the Marxist tradition is one of the most serious such paths on offer. If Ramakrishna's experiment

was about finding out whether different paths, walked with sincerity, lead to something real, then to exclude the tradition that has most rigorously pursued the outward question, why are some people powerful and others powerless, why do some have enough and others starve, would have been a failure of intellectual honesty.

## II. Neti, Neti: The Sociological Negation

The Advaita Vedanta tradition has a method of enquiry called Neti, Neti, not this, not this. You systematically negate everything that is not the self: not the body, not the senses, not the thoughts, not the emotions, not the social roles, not the identities. What remains, after everything false has been stripped away, is held to be the real self, the atman, the awareness that underlies all content.

The Marxist tradition does something similar, but at the collective level and in the opposite direction. Its method is also a systematic negation, but what it negates is the claimed naturalness of the given social order. Is this preference truly mine? Or is it a product of my class position, my conditioning, what I have been taught to want by a system that benefits from my wanting it? Is this value inherent? Or is it a tool of power, dressed in the language of necessity and common sense? Is this suffering the result of individual failing? Or is it the predictable output of a social arrangement that requires some people to be poor in order for others to be rich?

Not this. Not this. Not this.

The Marxist tradition calls what remains, after this stripping-away, class consciousness: the clear sight of social reality that comes once the ideological veil is lifted. It may not be the same as the atman that Vedanta is reaching toward. But the gesture is recognisably related, the patient, systematic refusal to accept the inherited account, and the insistence that what is real must be found by looking past what is presented.

There is a specific form of this that I find the most searching. Marx's concept of alienation, the separation of the worker from the product of their labour, from the process of production, from other workers, from their own human potential, is, in theological language, a description of Maya. A disconnection from reality so pervasive that it passes for the normal state of things. The alienated person does not know they are alienated, as the person trapped in Maya does not know they are trapped. This is what makes the condition so difficult to escape. And it is what makes the enquiry, both the spiritual enquiry inward and the structural enquiry outward, so necessary and so costly.

## III. The Meetings

I attended my first political meeting in October 2007, organised by the International Students for Social Equality at Manchester Metropolitan University. There were perhaps twenty people in the room. The speaker was a good orator who spoke about the Russian Revolution, the early years before Stalin's corruption, the ideal of a just society without exploitation. I found the argument compelling in outline and frustrating in detail, and interesting enough to attend again.

Over the next five years I attended meetings of most of the significant organisations on the British far left: the SWP, the Socialist Party, the Spartacist League, the Revolutionary Communist Group, the Communist League, the Socialist Equality Party, and several smaller groupings. I attended the Marxism Conference in London, Socialism 2009, the Convention of the Left, Palestine solidarity meetings, Libya solidarity meetings, workers' education seminars, Trotskyist reading groups, anarchist bookfairs. I did not join any of them. What the meetings offered, taken as a whole, was the experience of a world made visible through a different lens. The Marxist analysis of capitalism, the extraction of value from labour, the mechanisms of imperialism, the management of consent through culture and media, reorganises the social landscape as a spiritual practice reorganises the interior landscape. You begin to see what you previously did not see. The comfortable assumptions become visible as assumptions. The financial crisis of 2008, the rolling back of workers' gains by successive governments, the mechanisms by which the relative comfort of British workers was partly sustained by the exploitation of the global south, these were described with precision in the meetings I attended, and the description matched the observable world in ways that nothing else I encountered described it.

The enquiry, pursued seriously, also has personal consequences. At one of the workers' education seminars, someone asked what it meant, practically, concretely, that the relative prosperity of people in Britain was partly produced by

the exploitation of workers elsewhere. The question was not rhetorical. It was the outward-turned version of the question a meditator asks when they examine the sources of their own peace: is my contentment real? Or is it contingent on conditions that I have not examined, conditions that may themselves be unjust? The left's version of this question is less elegant than the Vedantic one. But it is at least as uncomfortable, and it has the advantage of being more immediately verifiable.

**IV. Solidarity as Seva**

The left groups I attended were organised around a principle that has an equivalent in almost every tradition examined in this book, though the left would reject the comparison as sentimental: the idea that the suffering of others constitutes a claim on you. In the ISKCON tradition, Ramakrishna's own Mission, service to human beings is service to God, Shiva Jnane Jiva Seva. In the Jain tradition, the recognition that every sentient being is an observer of the same fundamental nature as oneself generates the obligation of ahimsa. In Islam, the hunger of the neighbour is a test of faith's reality. In each case, the tradition builds a bridge between the vertical relationship with the ultimate reality and the horizontal relationship with the person standing next to you.

The left's version of this bridge is solidarity, the commitment to people who suffer not by accident but by design, which is a different thing from charity. Charity addresses the symptom. Solidarity addresses the cause. It is, a more demanding thing

than most of what the religious traditions ask of their practitioners, who are generally permitted to respond to poverty with generosity while leaving the structure that produces poverty intact. The Marxist tradition, at its best, does not permit this. It requires that you ask why the suffering exists, and it requires that the answer be allowed to make claims on your life.

The Marxism Conference at the Barbican in London in 2009 ended with a closing rally at which everyone stood, raised their fists, and sang the Internationale. I had never sung it before. The sound of a hundred people singing it together was not nothing. It was like singing Hare Krishna on a bus from Manchester to London, or Bismillah ir-rahman ir-rahim in a Manchester living room on Rumi's anniversary. Something collective, something oriented toward something larger than the individual self, something that required the body as well as the mind. The form was different. The gesture was the same.

## V. The Obstacles to Clear Enquiry

Every serious enquiry attracts the ego's attempt to colonise it. The spiritual seeker accumulates experiences and insights the way other people accumulate possessions, building a more elaborate, more impressively credentialled version of the self, what Trungpa called spiritual materialism. The left has its own version of this, and it is at least as common.

The Buddhist tradition has a precise vocabulary for what I watched operating in left meetings across five years. The Pali word tanha, craving, grasping, is not only craving for pleasant

experiences but the entire structure of the mind that divides everything into things to acquire and things to push away. Upadana, clinging, is what happens when tanha has operated long enough that the grasping has solidified into identity. And mana, conceit, is the subtle egoism that constructs and defends a sense of self through comparison: I have the correct analysis; you do not.

These were visible in the left meetings I attended with a regularity that became, over time, hard to ignore. The certainty with which each organisation held its position was not always intellectual confidence, it was mana, the need to be the one who sees clearly. The ferocity of the splits, the Spartacist League and the International Bolshevik Tendency, the SWP and Workers Power, the SEP and everyone else, each one producing a new organisation convinced it alone possessed the correct line, each requiring the same total commitment in exchange for the same righteous certainty. The structural analysis was precise. The analysis of the analysers was absent.

This is not an indictment of the left. It is a description of what happens to any enquiry when the enquirer is not also under scrutiny. The Jain tradition calls the corrective anekantavada, the many-sidedness of truth, the epistemological humility that insists: from where I stand I can see this part of the elephant. The revolutionary tradition, at its worst, insisted it could see the whole elephant, and that anyone who claimed to see a different part was either confused or in bad faith. This is the failure of meta-cognition, the failure to examine the one doing the examining, and the left has paid for it heavily. The Marxist

dismissal of interior examination as bourgeois individualism is one of the tradition's most costly errors. The mind's habits of grasping are not produced by capitalism. They are not resolved by structural change. They are the same habits that every tradition in this book addresses, each in its own way, and they will persist after the revolution if nothing is done about them before it.

## VI. What the Left Gives

The structural analysis itself is the most important gift, and no other tradition in this book offers it. The Bahai faith believes in the unity of humanity. The Jain tradition practices non-violence. The Christian traditions variously advocate for the poor. None of them has an equivalent to the Marxist analysis of why poverty persists despite all these commitments, an analysis that names the mechanism rather than merely lamenting the outcome. To say that all people are equal before God while leaving intact the arrangement that produces inequality is to offer comfort without enquiry. The left, at its best, refuses this.

The second gift is the community, the room in which people who are convinced that the arrangement of the world is unjust find each other and discover they are not alone. The Convention of the Left in Manchester was the first place I met an asylum seeker who showed me the electronic tag on her ankle and told me about her children in her home country, whom she tracked through a friend. That encounter was produced by a tradition that had organised itself around the

conviction that her situation was a political problem rather than a personal misfortune. The meeting created the room in which the encounter could happen.

The third gift is the demand for accountability that the left makes of the joto mot, toto path principle itself. All paths are valid as long as they are sincere, sincere about what? Valid for whom? The left's insistence on this question is not wrong. The spiritual path that produces genuine interior peace while leaving the structural causes of others' suffering unexamined is not necessarily a complete path. It may be a very comfortable one. This is, in fact, the question Trungpa raised at the level of the individual, is my peace genuine, or is it the peace of someone who has stopped looking?, raised now at the level of the social. The left applies the same scepticism to collective comfort that the interior traditions apply to individual comfort. Both are necessary. Neither on its own is enough.

## VII. What Ramakrishna Would Have Recognised

What would Ramakrishna have made of the Marxism Conference at the Barbican?

I think he would have recognised the gesture, if not the content. He would have seen the devotion: the total commitment to an enquiry, the community organised around it. He would have seen the soteriology: the revolution as the horizon toward which everything points, always deferred. He would have seen the schisms, the familiar human tendency to mistake one's own partial vision for the complete truth. He would have seen the singing of the Internationale and

recognised it as kirtan: collective sound directed toward something larger than the individual self. He would, I think, have been moved by the sincerity, and troubled by the pattern. He would have asked, I think, whether anyone in the room was being transformed, not in their analysis of the external world, but in the interior qualities he took to be the markers of genuine progress: the loosening of ego-identification, the expansion of compassion, the growing capacity to recognise something worth caring about in every face. He would have noticed that the tradition had the most precise vocabulary available for describing how the world produces suffering, and almost none for describing what happens to the person inside the tradition as they inhabit it.

Ramakrishna saw the divine in everyone he met, in the prostitute, in the sceptic, in the scholar who came to argue and stayed to listen. The left sees the structural chains that created the conditions in which the prostitute operates, in which the sceptic was formed, in which the scholar's scholarship was made possible. Both are looking at the same person. Neither account is complete without the other. The water in this ghat is not the same water as in the Kali temple or the mosque. But it is water. The thirst it addresses is real.

The best moments of my political engagement were not the moments of ideological clarity, when the correct analysis became sharp and the right position clear. They were the moments of actual encounter with actual people. The asylum seeker with the ankle tag. The overnight discussion with IT workers in Bangalore at two in the morning, one of them

describing his colleague's suicide with the helplessness of someone who could see something was wrong but did not yet have the tools to name it. The Libyan students at the Green Fish Resource Centre who told me: yes, NATO is there for the oil, and there are a hundred thousand people facing massacre in Benghazi. Both are true. What do you do?

In those moments, something was present that no analysis quite reached. Call it the specific weight of another person's reality. Call it the claim that suffering makes when it is no longer statistical but present, in the room, in a face. Whatever it was, it was in the same register as the Nizamuddin dargah offered, and the ISKCON temple, and the Quaker meeting house. The form was entirely different. The quality was familiar.

This chapter does not conclude that the political left is secretly a religion, or that structural self-enquiry and interior self-enquiry are the same enquiry. They are not. The interior traditions ask what suffering is, and find their answers in the nature of consciousness. The left asks where suffering comes from, and finds its answers in the nature of social organisation. Both questions are genuine. Both require discipline, sincerity, a willingness to be changed by what you find. The experiment this book describes was conducted in both directions. I cannot claim the results were equal. Both directions led somewhere. It did not ask me to transcend the world. It asked me to take it seriously. That, too, is a spiritual discipline. Or at least, I could not find a better name for it.

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# Chapter Nine

## *The Water Itself: Buddhism and the Ramakrishna Experiment*

> *There is no jhāna for one without wisdom; no wisdom for one without jhāna. But for one with both jhāna and wisdom, nibbāna is near.*
>
> — *Dhammapada, verse 372*

> *Read widely. Practise narrowly. Compare slowly. Let understanding follow experience.*
>
> — *working principle of a practitioner*

### I. The Paradox

Of all the paths in the Ramakrishna experiment, Buddhism presents the most unusual methodological problem. Every other tradition described in this book was encountered from the outside: I arrived at the mosque, the Jain temple, the interfaith banquet, the political meeting as a visitor from a Hindu-background with a Buddhist practice. The Buddhist tradition was not a destination. It was, for most of the period this book describes, the lens through which everything else was seen.

I came to Buddhist meditation practice not through intellectual conviction but through the practice of sitting, which I

encountered in England in 2003 and which answered something that other traditions had not quite reached. It is difficult to describe what sitting practice answers, and I will not pretend to be able to describe it completely. What I can say is that there is a specific quality of stillness available in sustained seated meditation that is different from prayer, from chanting, from praise, from intellectual study, from ethical commitment, different not in kind but in direction. Where most spiritual practices direct attention outward toward God, or inward toward feeling, or forward toward liberation, the meditation practice I was encountering directed attention to the present moment itself, to the structure of experience before it has been organised by concept and preference and memory. Something about that direction answered something in me that the other directions did not.

This created a paradox for the Ramakrishna experiment. I was trying to walk multiple paths simultaneously, to find out from the inside what each one offered. But I was doing this while maintaining a daily practice (thirty to sixty minutes of sitting most mornings, retreats when possible) in a tradition that is in some ways antithetical to the simultaneous sampling of multiple paths. The Buddhist tradition warns against exactly the kind of promiscuous spiritual engagement that the experiment required: deep practice requires sustained commitment to a single vehicle, and the practitioner who moves between methods sampling each tradition's beginner instructions will

perpetually encounter the entry-level phenomenology and never reach the depths where the traditions' convergences become visible.

I was, in other words, doing the experiment wrong by Buddhist standards. And yet the experiment produced something. And the Buddhist practice, running underneath all of it, shaped what I noticed and what I was able to receive. This chapter is an attempt to make that relationship explicit.

## II. One City, Many Rooms

Manchester in the years I was there contained, within a few miles' radius, the following Buddhist groups all operating simultaneously: a Theravada concentration group teaching a pre-reform Thai jhana method at least five hundred years old; a Burmese temple running weekly vipassana in the Mahasi Sayadaw tradition; a Thai temple using a method involving the visualisation of a luminous sphere and the mantra *sammā arahaṃ*; a Korean Zen group chanting the Heart Sutra in Korean, performing 108 prostrations, and sitting facing a blank wall; a Tibetan Buddhist group receiving teachings from visiting lamas; a Chinese Mahayana temple running weekly chanting and discussion; a Zen group in a Quaker basement alternating between silent illumination and koan practice; and a small Jodo Shinshu community chanting *Namu Amida Butsu* and studying Shinran.

These groups did not talk to each other. Each taught its method as the path to liberation. Each had practitioners who had sat for decades.

Attending several of them, which I did across nearly a decade, left me with a question that none of the groups provided the tools to answer: what is the relationship between what is happening in these rooms? When the elderly Thai teacher instructs the lengthening of the breath and the Korean Zen teacher instructs the holding of a question, and the Jodo Shinshu teacher instructs the complete surrender of self-effort, are these three technologies for the same transformation? Or three different transformations? Or three descriptions of one movement that cannot be captured by any single description?

This is the *joto mot, toto path* question applied within a single tradition. Ramakrishna's experiment was conducted across different traditions; the Buddhist experiment was conducted within one. But the question has the same structure: are the paths genuinely different, or do they converge at depth?

## III. The Samatha and the Vipassana

The standard account of Buddhist meditation distinguishes two types: samatha, concentration practice, which develops stillness and absorption; and vipassana, insight practice, which develops clear seeing into the nature of experience. The standard account presents these as two valid but different approaches, you might

do one before the other, or combine them, or emphasise one over the other depending on your temperament.

The actual history, as I came to understand it through years of practice and study, is considerably more complicated. The dominant form of meditation in contemporary Western Buddhism (the mindfulness tradition associated with Mahasi Sayadaw and S.N. Goenka, which has been extracted and repackaged as the global mindfulness movement) is historically recent, constructed in colonial-era Burma in the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, and rose to dominance through a specific sequence of historical and political accidents rather than through doctrinal superiority.

Before this construction, Theravada meditation was dominated by a system called *borān kammaṭṭhāna*, the old meditation subjects, which was suppressed three times: by Thai royal reform, by colonial-era Buddhist modernism, and by the rise of the Burmese vipassana movement. By the late twentieth century it had been nearly destroyed. A small fragment survived in Wales, maintained by a single Thai practitioner who had arrived in England in the 1960s and taught an unchanged method to a small group of Westerners who eventually became the UK Samatha Trust.

I encountered this group, and encountered its implications for understanding the relationship between the various Buddhist meditation methods, and the encounter changed how I

understood the question Ramakrishna was asking. If within a single tradition, Theravada Buddhism, there are methods so different that their practitioners would struggle to recognise each other's practice as the same activity, what does it mean to claim that all traditions lead to the same place? The claim might be true and still require a much more precise account of *in what sense* it is true.

## IV. The Korean Zen Overnight

The single most disorienting Buddhist practice I encountered was the Korean Zen overnight retreat: arriving at six in the evening, 108 prostrations before sitting, chanting the Heart Sutra in Korean, then forty-minute periods of sitting meditation facing a blank wall, interspersed with walking meditation in single file, continuing until five the next morning. The instruction for the sitting was: hold the question *What is this?* in the whole of your being. Don't make anything. Don't hold anything. Don't attach to anything. Just go straight: don't know.

This is not samatha. It is not vipassana in the Mahasi sense. It is not anything that fits the standard two-type taxonomy. The don't-know mind is neither concentrated on an object nor clearly seeing the impermanence of arising phenomena. It is holding a question open (radically, structurally, as a practice) until the question becomes larger than the questioner and something happens that cannot be anticipated in advance.

What happens is difficult to describe without either overclaiming or underclaiming. In my own experience, across several overnight sittings: periods of the most extreme boredom I have ever experienced, followed by periods in which the boredom simply dropped away and what remained was a quality of attention that had no content but was nevertheless completely vivid. Not a mystical experience in the sense of visions or feelings of unity. More like: the question dissolving without being answered. A specific quality of not-knowing that was not confused but clear.

The Korean Zen community framed this in terms of what they called the *great doubt*: the state in which the holding of the question has become so total that ordinary conceptual consciousness is suspended and something else becomes available. Whether that something else is the same as what Ramakrishna described as samadhi, or the same as the Quaker meeting's quality of gathered attention, or the same as what the Sufi whirling practitioner described as losing the ordinary boundaries of the self, I cannot say with certainty. But the quality of the not-knowing mind was recognisably related to something I had encountered in each of those other contexts.

## V. Jodo Shinshu and the Failure of Self-Power

The most philosophically challenging Buddhist tradition I encountered was Jodo Shinshu: the tradition founded by

Shinran in thirteenth-century Japan, which holds that all self-directed practice (all meditation, all effort, all technique) reinforces the ego's illusion that liberation can be achieved through one's own power, and that the only genuine liberation comes through complete surrender to the compassion of Amida Buddha.

The Jodo Shinshu teaching, stated baldly: you cannot meditate your way to liberation. Every technique is a subtle form of the same grasping that is the problem. The only thing that works is the recognition (not as an idea but as a direct experience) that you have already been held, always, by a compassion that does not require you to be anything other than what you are. This recognition is called *shinjin*: an entrusting of the self to Amida's Vow. It cannot be produced by effort. It arises, when it arises, by grace.

This is a radical challenge to every other Buddhist tradition in this book, and to every other tradition in the entire Ramakrishna experiment. The Korean Zen teacher says: hold the question with your whole being and something will happen. The Mahasi vipassana teacher says: observe arising phenomena with sustained non-reactive attention and liberation will come. The ISKCON prabhu says: chant the maha-mantra with full attention and Krishna will respond. Each of these proposes a method. Jodo Shinshu says: all methods are the problem.

What Jodo Shinshu points at (and what I found genuinely clarifying rather than merely contrarian) is the question of what exactly is doing the seeking in any spiritual practice. If the seeker is the ego looking for liberation, then the seeking is itself a form of grasping, and every method that feeds the seeker is counterproductive. The Ramakrishna experiment, if this analysis is correct, has a structural problem: a Bengali software engineer deciding to test the unity of religions by systematically attending different traditions is the ego-driven seeking that Shinran identified as the obstacle rather than the path.

I do not think this fully refutes the experiment. Ramakrishna himself was, by all accounts, a person of such deep personal surrender (someone for whom the ego-driven seeking had been so thoroughly dissolved by years of devotional practice before the experiment began) that the systematic testing of different paths was conducted, in his case, from a position of genuine openness rather than from a position of ego-project. I cannot claim the same. But the Jodo Shinshu analysis at least names something real: the *ego of the seeker* is not incidental to the experiment. It shapes what is found.

## VI. What Sits Underneath

The Buddhist practice that ran underneath all of the other encounters in this book was primarily in the Tibetan tradition, specifically the Nyingma Dzogchen lineage, which I received

teachings and empowerments in across several years. I will not describe the specific practices in detail, both because their full meaning requires transmission and because attempting to describe what I did not fully understand would be dishonest.

What I can say is what the tradition offered that the other traditions did not. The Tibetan framework is, among Buddhist systems, the most explicit about the relationship between what is being practiced and what is ultimately being pointed at. The practice is not building toward something that is absent. The practice is recognising something that is already the case but is obscured by the ordinary operations of mind. The natural state of awareness, what the tradition calls *rigpa* in Dzogchen, is not a goal to be achieved but a recognition to be made, of what has always been present but has been overlooked in the preoccupation with experience's content.

This maps onto something Ramakrishna said repeatedly: that the divine was not hidden or distant, but was present in everything and everyone, continuously available, overlooked only because attention was directed elsewhere. The Jain teacher's analogy of the film projector, you are watching the movie and have forgotten that you are the screen, shares the same pattern. The Quaker Inner Light that is accessible to everyone without intermediary shares the same pattern. The Islamic teaching on the nearness of Allah, *We are nearer to him*

*than his jugular vein*: this shares the same pattern. The Gita's atman, present in every being, shares it.

What the Tibetan tradition gave me was a framework for understanding why Ramakrishna might have found the same presence through every path: not because all paths lead to a distant destination by different routes, but because every sincere practice, whatever its form, creates conditions in which the mind pauses its habitual activity long enough for something already present to be recognised. The stillness in the Quaker meeting. The dissolution in the Korean Zen not-knowing. The absorption in the ISKCON bhajan. The surrender in the UPC praise. The silence in the Sufi *Hoo*. In each case, something is being interrupted. And what the interruption allows to be noticed (what is there when the ordinary noise quiets) this may be what Ramakrishna kept finding, and kept recognising as the same.

## VII. The Limit

I am aware that the previous section leans toward the universalist conclusion that the *joto mot, toto path* principle is simply, straightforwardly, true. I want to resist this conclusion, or at least to hold it more carefully than it is usually held.

The traditions are not the same. The differences between Jodo Shinshu and Korean Zen are not surface differences of culture and vocabulary. They are differences in what human beings are,

what is wrong with ordinary consciousness, and what liberation consists of. The difference between the Gita's Vaishnava dualism and Advaita Vedanta's non-dualism is not a cultural preference. It is a disagreement about the fundamental nature of reality. The Bahai faith's progressive revelation and the Jain tradition's anekantavada are compatible in some ways and incompatible in others. The Marxist analysis of capitalism and the Buddhist analysis of interior suffering are both real and both incomplete in ways that do not neatly complement each other.

The honest conclusion, after all of this, is not that all paths lead to the same place. It is that every sincere path leads *somewhere real* (somewhere that is not available from outside the path, that requires genuine engagement to access, that has a specific texture and quality distinct from any other path's destination. Whether these destinations are the same destination seen from different angles, or adjacent destinations in the same vast territory, or entirely different territories whose family resemblance is a projection of the observer) this is the question that I cannot finally answer, and that I am not sure anyone can answer from the position of a single lifetime.

What the Buddhist practice gave the experiment was not the answer. It gave the ability to sit with the question without the question becoming unbearable. The not-knowing mind, which Korean Zen cultivates as a formal practice but which every sustained meditation practice approaches from its own

direction, is the appropriate epistemological posture for this inquiry. Not the certainty that all paths converge. Not the scepticism that none of them leads anywhere. The *syat* of the Jain tradition: perhaps. From this perspective. As far as I can see.

Which is, it turns out, exactly what Ramakrishna said. He did not claim to have proved that all paths converge. He claimed to have found the same presence through each. He reported his experience. He did not systematise it. He sat with the question in his own way, by going deeper rather than broader, by allowing each path to define his experience rather than remaining its observer.

I went broader. It produced a different kind of finding: not the depth of the convergence, but the width of the territory. Not the same light at every path's end, but the same quality of turn (the same gesture of sincere orientation toward what is larger than the self) present in every tradition I encountered. Including, I will say, the ones that would refuse the comparison. Including, unexpectedly, the political meeting in a Manchester pub where someone explained why the revolution was still coming.

The water is the water. I cannot prove it is the same water. But it is water, everywhere I have found it. And that finding is not nothing.

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# Chapter Ten

## *The End of Seeking: Encountering U.G. Krishnamurti*

*There are encounters that add something to your understanding, and there are encounters that remove the ground on which understanding stands.*
*This was the second kind.*

### I. The Warning

I first came across U.G. Krishnamurti in December 2005, in Manchester, through a Buddhist online forum that I had been reading with increasing seriousness. The discussions there were careful and largely technical, about meditation techniques, stages of absorption, the phenomenology of attention. They were the conversations of people mapping an inner territory with the seriousness of cartographers. I had found, in them, a community of inquiry that took the interior life as a legitimate object of study.

Someone mentioned U.G. in passing. Not as a teacher. Almost as a warning. There was a link to a website and references to three books: Mind is a Myth, Mystique of Enlightenment, The Courage to Stand Alone. I clicked without expecting very much. Uppaluri Gopala Krishnamurti, who insisted he was not related to the more famous Jiddu Krishnamurti, and who

seemed to regard the confusion itself as emblematic of the spiritual marketplace's capacity for self-deception, was born in Andhra Pradesh in 1918 and died in Italy in 2007. He had, by his own account, spent years as a serious student of spiritual traditions: he sat with Ramana Maharshi, studied with the Theosophical Society, attended talks by Jiddu Krishnamurti for seventeen years. And then, in 1967, something happened to his body that he described as a "calamity", a biological event, not a mystical one, that left him in a state he refused to call enlightenment, refused to call awakening, and spent the rest of his life insisting had no relationship whatsoever to anything any spiritual tradition had ever promised.

## II. The Voice

Before the books, there were videos. U.G. sitting in a chair (usually in someone's living room, surrounded by visitors who had come from various distances to sit with him) answering questions in a tone that was flat, almost dismissive, as though the questions themselves were already based on a misunderstanding he had no interest in correcting gently. He was not hostile. He was not unkind. But he had a particular capacity for removing, from any question put to him, the very ground on which the question seemed to rest.

Someone asked whether meditation could lead to enlightenment. U.G.'s answer was not that it could not, it was that there is no enlightenment. Not that the path is difficult. Not that most practitioners fail. That the destination does not

exist. That the tradition of meditation is the tradition of a journey toward something that was never there.

At one point, he referred to the Buddha as a fraud. The word was not qualified. It was not softened. It was not framed as a reinterpretation or a critique within a shared framework. It was simply stated. I remember the reaction clearly, not agreement, not immediate rejection, but something closer to shock. Not because the Buddha cannot be criticised, every tradition I had encountered contained internal critiques of its founders, but because of the way the statement functioned. It did not invite discussion. It removed the context in which discussion was possible.

This is, I eventually understood, the point. U.G. was not interested in arguing within the frameworks of existing traditions. He was interested in demonstrating (through the very quality of his speech, its bluntness, its refusal of spiritual vocabulary) that the frameworks themselves were the problem. Every tradition provides a map. U.G.'s position was that the map is what prevents you from seeing the territory, because the territory has no resemblance to any map ever drawn of it.

## III. The Position

The books were consistent with the videos. U.G.'s central claims can be stated simply, though their implications are less simple. There is no enlightenment. There is no liberation. All gurus are perpetuating a fraud, not necessarily consciously, but inevitably, because the tradition of spiritual teaching sustains

in the student the sense of lack that it promises to cure. The search itself is the disease. The culture of seeking, retreats, teachers, practices, the accumulation of experience toward some imagined arrival, is not a remedy for the human condition. It is one of its most refined expressions.

What you call the mind is a construct. What you call the self is maintained by thought. The body functions perfectly well without any of this elaboration (without the continuous narrative of self-improvement, the comparison with how one was yesterday or might be tomorrow. The body breathes, digests, moves, perceives. Thought intervenes and turns this biological functioning into a project, a drama, a spiritual career. That intervention is not necessary. It is not helpful. It cannot be voluntarily stopped) every attempt to stop it is itself thought continuing. But it can, U.G. insisted, cease. Not by technique, not by practice, not by the following of any instruction. By something else entirely, which cannot be taught and cannot be transmitted.

He was precise about what this meant for spiritual teaching. A teacher who says “follow this practice and you will reach liberation” is not lying, exactly. They may have had some significant experience. But in offering it as a path for others, they have already misrepresented it, because the experience cannot be the result of following a path, and every student who follows the path will be oriented toward an outcome that the path cannot produce. The teacher keeps the student searching. The search keeps the student needful. The needfulness keeps

the teacher necessary. The whole system perpetuates itself under the name of liberation.

## IV. The Removal

Up to that point, my encounters with different traditions had been, in a certain sense, cumulative. Each added something. A practice, a perspective, a way of understanding experience that could be held alongside the others, even when they did not fully align. There was, beneath all of them, a shared assumption that I had never examined directly: that there is something to be found. That the search, however complex and however long, is meaningful. That the act of turning toward the divine (in whatever form the turning takes) is an act that goes somewhere real.

U.G. did not offer a different path. He questioned the assumption. Not: this path is mistaken. Not: there is a better path. But: the idea of a path is mistaken. The framework within which all the traditions I had been encountering operated (the framework of seeker and sought, of practice leading toward arrival, of the human being as someone in need of transformation) was itself, in his analysis, the problem. This was not an addition to my understanding. It was a removal.

I had visited the Bahai Lotus Temple and found in it a theology of universal access. I had sat at the Nizamuddin dargah and felt the particular quality of a tradition built around surrender. I had attended ISKCON classes and chanted on a bus from Manchester to London and felt the warmth of a devotional world organised around love for a named divine figure. I had

sat in Quaker silence and in Jain meditation halls and in Jesuit retreat houses and in Pentecostal churches where the walls seemed to breathe with collective praise. In each of these, whatever my reservations, I had recognised something real, some contact with something that exceeded ordinary experience.

U.G.'s position said: what you recognised was a product of expectation. The presence you felt in the dargah was a function of the story you brought into it. The warmth in the ISKCON temple was the warmth of collective human longing, nothing more. The silence in the Quaker meeting house was simply silence, and the meaning you found in it was yours, not the room's. He would not have been aggressive about this. He would have said it flatly, as a matter of description, as if pointing at something that should have been obvious all along.

## V. The Effect

The effect was not clarity. It was a kind of blankness, not dramatic, not overwhelming, but persistent enough to be noticeable. The activities I had been engaged in did not stop immediately. But their orientation changed. I would arrive at a temple or a study circle carrying a question that U.G. would have identified as the problem rather than the inquiry: what is happening here that I could call real? If there is no enlightenment, what is all this for? If all gurus are frauds, what am I doing listening to them? If the search itself sustains the illusion, what does it mean that I am searching?

These questions did not lead to new practices. They led, instead, to a reduction of meaning. The specific texture of each tradition (which had been, until then, something I approached with curiosity and a kind of appetite) became harder to inhabit without an awareness that the appetite itself was being questioned. This lasted for several months. In its most acute form it lasted perhaps three or four months; in a diluted form it has never entirely passed.

What made U.G.'s position particularly difficult to dismiss was that it was not primarily an argument. Arguments can be countered. His position was more like a demonstration, a demonstration, enacted through his manner and his refusal of every spiritual framework offered to him, that the thing being sought and the activity of seeking it were aspects of the same structure, and that the structure could not be escaped from within the structure. You cannot think your way out of the mind's operation, because the thinking is the operation. You cannot practice your way to the end of seeking, because the practicing is the seeking continuing in a new form.

## VI. The Conversations

I spoke about these ideas with friends, particularly those from the Buddhist circles where I had first encountered the reference. The conversations were difficult, not because of hostility, but because the position itself leaves little room for engagement. To question a method is one thing. To question the goal is another. To question the entire structure within which both method and goal exist is something else entirely, it

forecloses the usual moves of the conversation before they can be made.

Some friendships became strained. With others, I withdrew, not out of disagreement alone but because it was not clear how to continue the conversation within a shared frame. The Buddhist forum where I had first encountered U.G. had been predicated on the shared assumption that meditation practice was pointing at something real and reachable. If that assumption was withdrawn, what were we discussing? We were discussing, it would seem, our own elaborate investment in a story about transformation. This was not a comfortable conversation to have, and most people preferred not to have it.

What I noticed, in the responses of those I spoke with, was instructive. The most common response was not counter-argument. It was a kind of closure. People would say: this is a position that destroys itself, because if nothing is true then U.G.'s position is also not true. Or: he is clearly describing something he experienced, so he must have had an experience, so the possibility of transformation is intact. Or, more simply: I don't find this helpful. I am going back to my practice.

Each of these responses was understandable. Each of them was also, in its own way, what U.G. would have predicted. The position generates the response. The response generates a return to the position, slightly modified. Nothing changes except the quality of the practitioner's discomfort.

## VII. The Appeal and the Limit

There was, nevertheless, an element of appeal in what U.G. was saying. If there is nothing to achieve, then there is nothing to fail at. If the entire structure of seeking is unnecessary, then the effort, the comparison, the subtle measurement of progress, all of this can be set aside. There is a kind of relief in that. A reduction. Nothing to become. Nothing to attain. The weight of the spiritual project, which I had not previously identified as weight, became briefly visible as weight when it was offered the possibility of being removed.

But the relief did not resolve into something stable. Because while the position removed the goal, it did not provide a way of living that felt complete. If there is no search, what takes its place? If meaning is constructed, what does one do with the persistent sense that something matters? U.G. would say that the question itself is part of the problem (that the demand for meaning is the continuation of the same movement. This may be so. But it was not, for me, sufficient. The blankness that followed his position did not feel like liberation. It felt like a room from which the furniture had been removed) not emptied into spaciousness, but simply emptied.

There is also this. U.G. was himself, by any standard measure, seeking something, or had been, for most of his life. The seventeen years spent attending Jiddu Krishnamurti's talks, the years with the Theosophical Society, the sustained engagement with Ramana Maharshi: these were not the activities of a man indifferent to the question of what the human being is and what, if anything, it is capable of. His "calamity" of 1967 came after decades of intensive search. The

position he arrived at, that the search is the disease, was arrived at by searching. This is not a refutation of his position. It may, in fact, be the most interesting thing about it.

## VIII. The Return

There was no clear moment of decision. No turning point. Only a gradual sense that something was missing, not the goal that U.G. had removed, but something in the engagement itself, in the act of attending, listening, participating. The purely negative position did not account for whatever that was.

And so, slowly, I returned. To the temples, the discussions, the encounters. Not with the same assumption as before, the assumption that there is a destination and that attending these places is a form of travelling toward it. But not entirely without direction either. What I returned with was something I can only describe as the habit of contact: a reluctance to give up on the encounters themselves, even when the framework that had given them their meaning had been seriously damaged.

The questions U.G. had introduced did not disappear. They remained as background, as a kind of persistent counterpoint to every subsequent encounter. What if the goal is the problem? What if enlightenment is a projection sustained by the act of seeking it? What if the dissatisfaction that drives the search is amplified, not resolved, by the promise of its end?

These questions did not stop the experiment. But they changed its terms. They changed what I was looking for, and what I thought I could honestly claim to have found.

## IX. What Remains

The chapters that precede this one describe encounters with traditions that assert something, about God, about liberation, about the nature of reality. Each tradition I encountered had, at its centre, a claim: that there is something to be found, that it can be approached through the tradition's practices, and that finding it is worth organising a human life around. The specific claim varies dramatically, the Jain's liberation through non-reaction is a very different thing from the Christian's salvation through grace, but the structure is the same. There is a destination. There is a path. Walking the path reaches the destination.

This chapter describes an encounter with a position that questions that structure. Not from outside all frameworks (U.G. was as positioned as anyone else) but from a position that refused to accept the consolations the frameworks offered in exchange for the position. He left, in place of those consolations, an open space. An open space is not nothing. But it is also not a path.

What the encounter with U.G. left me with, in the end, was not the conclusion that the experiment was worthless. It was the recognition that the experiment had been operating on an assumption that had never been examined (the assumption that there is something to be found) and that this assumption was not self-evidently true. Whether it is true or false is a question I cannot answer. But the fact that it had been so thoroughly unquestioned, across so many traditions and so many visits and so many encounters, was itself something

worth noting. The seeker had been, in a certain sense, the last thing the experiment examined.

## X. What Ramakrishna Would Have Made of It

Ramakrishna's entire life was a sustained, passionate search. He wept for the Divine, practised one path after another with ferocious sincerity, and reported finding the same luminous presence through each. U.G. would have called the whole project a fraud, the search itself the disease, the reported visions mere products of a mind caught in its own movement. The presence Ramakrishna found through Kali and through Islam and through Christ would be, in U.G.'s analysis, a projection of the mind that had already been shaped, by decades of practice, to expect precisely that kind of encounter.

I suspect Ramakrishna would have listened to U.G. with the same unblinking attention he gave everyone, the snake charmers, the prostitutes, the sceptics who came to Dakshineswar to challenge him and went home changed, and then smiled that gentle, slightly mischievous smile and continued exactly as before. Not out of denial, but out of a direct knowing that the presence he met was not dependent on the search, yet could not have been met without it. The contradiction stands. U.G. removes the ladder. Ramakrishna climbs it anyway and finds, at the top, that the ladder was never necessary, yet the climbing was.

This is, finally, the tension that U.G. introduces into the *joto mot, toto path* principle. Ramakrishna's principle says: as many opinions, so many paths. All sincere paths lead to the

same destination. U.G.'s principle says: there is no destination. All paths, however sincere, are going nowhere, because nowhere is where they lead, and nowhere is already here, and the person looking for it is the one thing preventing them from noticing.

These two positions cannot both be true in the same sense. But I have found myself unable, in the years since reading U.G.'s books, to simply set either one aside. The experiments I undertook in those temples and mosques and meeting houses were not illusions. Something happened in them. U.G.'s position was also not, in my experience, simply wrong, the seeker's project is compromised in the ways he described, and the compromise is real. The honest position, after all of this, is to hold both: that the encounters were genuine, and that the seeker was implicated in everything they produced. Not a synthesis. Not a dismissal. Only the open space where the question used to stand, and the continuing fact of the encounters, which go on whether or not one has decided what to make of them.

The tank has several ghats. People drink from different places. The water is the same. Or perhaps there is no water, only the drinking. Or perhaps both statements are beside the point.

Joto mot, toto path.

Even this.

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# Chapter Eleven

## *The Problem of Contradiction*

*In what sense can all of these be true at the same time?*

### I. The Table

The previous chapter left a specific problem unsolved. After encountering U.G. Krishnamurti, the question was no longer simply whether the paths lead to the same place. It was whether the entire frame of the experiment — the seeker, the seeking, the notion of a destination — was itself part of the problem. And yet the experiences accumulated over the preceding years did not disappear. The presence felt at the dargah of Nizamuddin Awliya, the stillness before the stone giant of Bahubali, the warmth in the church hall, the austere clarity of the Jain cosmology — these remained as stubborn facts of experience, whatever theoretical framework one brought to bear on them. The question, then, did not vanish. It changed its form.

At one of the interfaith dinners at St Peter's Chaplaincy in Manchester, the change became unavoidable. These were evenings where curry was passed around long tables and representatives of different traditions spoke in turn, usually with goodwill and patience, usually at a level of generality that allowed everyone to agree. On this particular evening,

something different happened. The claims that emerged from three of the speakers sat on the table together and refused to coexist gracefully. The contradiction between them was not a matter of vocabulary or emphasis. It was structural. And I found, sitting there, that I could no longer smooth it over with the kind of harmonising instinct I had been relying on throughout the experiment.

## II. The Claims

The Islamic speaker went first. God is one, without partner, without equal, without form that could be mistaken for a creature. The central act of a human life is submission to that reality — islam, in its literal sense — and the structure of prayer, law, and moral discipline is not a cultural overlay on some universal spiritual core. It is the shape that a life correctly oriented toward its source actually takes. The good is not constructed from within the individual. It is given, revealed, and available to anyone who submits. There was clarity in this, an austere and genuine clarity I had felt before, standing in the courtyard at Nizamuddin and again in the mosque in Didsbury, where the absolute oneness of the divine was not a philosophical conclusion but the ground on which everything else was built.

The Jain speaker presented a cosmology that was, in its structure, incompatible with the first. There is no creator God. The universe has always existed and will always exist, governed by laws that operate without divine supervision or intervention. What the Islamic tradition calls God's will,

Jainism understands as the impersonal operation of karma, which is not metaphor but a fine material substance that attaches itself to the soul through reaction and obscures its natural luminosity. Liberation in this framework is not submission to another. It is purification of the self through disciplined non-violence and the gradual withdrawal of the soul from karmic accumulation. It is an achievement of the individual soul, and it owes nothing to grace.

Running beneath the conversation, and present in my mind as a third position, was the Advaita Vedanta that had been part of my intellectual inheritance since childhood. There is no individual self. The sense of "I" that the Islamic tradition asks to submit and the Jain tradition asks to purify is, in the Advaitic analysis, a construction — a superimposition on the underlying reality, which is non-dual, Brahman, without second. The world of multiplicity appears and functions, but it does not have independent existence. What the other traditions are calling liberation is, in this framework, the recognition that the self you have been defending and refining and purifying is, in the end, not there. Not submission. Not purification. Dissolution.

And then the Christian position, which I had encountered in churches and Bible study circles and in a Jesuit retreat and which resisted being absorbed into any of the others. Salvation is through Christ. Not as a symbol, not as one instantiation of a universal principle of divine love, but as a specific historical and theological claim: that in the life, death, and resurrection of Jesus, something decisive occurred in the relationship

between God and humanity that cannot be reproduced by any amount of individual discipline or philosophical insight. Grace is not self-generated. The human being does not climb to God. God descends. Whatever we arrive at through our own efforts, the tradition insists that what is actually required cannot be obtained that way. It must be received.

## III. Where the Edges Meet

Each of these positions, taken individually, has a coherent internal logic. Each is held, by serious people who have thought carefully about it, not as a preference but as a description of reality. The difficulty arises precisely at the points where they meet each other, because at those points they are not describing different aspects of the same reality. They are making incompatible claims about the same questions.

If there is one God who created the universe and who commands and sustains it, then the Jain insistence that the universe has no creator is not a variation on that truth from a different cultural angle. It is a contradiction. The universe either has a creator or it does not. If the individual self is ultimately unreal — if the deepest insight available to a human being is that the "I" is a superimposition on undifferentiated awareness — then both the Islamic project of submitting that self and the Jain project of purifying it are operating under a fundamental misapprehension about the nature of what they are working with. If salvation depends on a specific relationship to the person of Christ, then paths that do not pass

through that relationship are, from within the Christian framework, insufficient. These are not differences of emphasis. They are differences of structure, and the differences matter. What struck me, sitting at that table, was not the fact of disagreement — I had known the traditions disagreed — but something subtler: the discovery that I had been managing the disagreement rather than engaging with it. The harmonising instinct I had brought to the experiment had been doing real intellectual work, quietly, in the background, preventing the contradictions from becoming sharp enough to require a response. When that management failed, what was left was a question I had not properly asked: in what sense can all of these be true at the same time?

## IV. The Temptation to Translate

The first response to this question presents itself almost automatically, and I had been using it without fully noticing. It is the move of translation: when Islam speaks of God, you say, it is pointing to what Vedanta calls Brahman. When Jainism denies a creator, it is denying a particular anthropomorphic conception of deity, not the ultimate reality. When Christianity speaks of Christ as the only way, it is expressing a universal principle of divine self-giving that can be found, in different forms, elsewhere. In other words, you take the specific claims of each tradition and map them onto a shared conceptual framework — usually one derived, without acknowledgement, from one of the traditions themselves — in which the apparent

contradictions dissolve because the terms have been redescribed.

This move has genuine advantages. It preserves the intuition, which I could not easily dismiss, that each tradition was in genuine contact with something real. It creates a space in which traditions can be discussed together without the conversation immediately becoming competitive. And it resonates, at least on the surface, with the principle I had set out to explore. But it has a cost that becomes apparent on closer inspection. In translating, you stop hearing what the tradition is actually saying. The Islamic insistence on the absolute oneness and unpartneredness of God is not a general statement about ultimate reality that could, with careful reinterpretation, be shown to be compatible with Advaitic non-dualism. It is a specific claim that shapes a specific form of life. When you translate it into something else, you have not understood it better. You have replaced it with something more comfortable.

Translation, taken far enough, becomes a form of erasure. It turns each tradition into a local dialect of a universal language that none of the traditions themselves would recognise or endorse. The Jain denial of a creator cannot be reinterpreted as a metaphor without negating the entire cosmological structure on which Jain ethics depends. The Christian claim about Christ cannot be universalised into a symbol without stepping away from the claim itself. To say “they all mean the same thing at a deeper level” is, in many cases, to say “I have decided what the deeper level is, and I am now reading each

tradition in light of my decision." This is not comparative religion. It is the imposition of one view while appearing to honour many.

## V. Anekantavada and Its Limits

The Jain doctrine of anekantavada — the many-sidedness of reality — had seemed to me, when I first encountered it, among the most philosophically sophisticated responses to the problem of competing truth claims. Every assertion is true from a particular standpoint. No single perspective is complete. The classic illustration is the parable of the blind men and the elephant: each touches a different part and reports a different shape, each is right from where they stand, and the apparent contradictions between their reports are resolved not by declaring one of them correct but by recognising that they are each describing something real from a limited position.

The doctrine is genuinely illuminating about a certain class of disagreements. It captures something important about the partiality of perspective and the danger of treating one's own vantage point as the view from nowhere. But it does not dissolve the kind of contradiction I was looking at, because the blind men's reports, while apparently conflicting, are not actually incompatible. One says the elephant is like a wall, another says it is like a rope, and both can be accommodated within a single description of the animal. They are describing different parts of the same object.

The traditions I was considering were, at certain points, doing something different. They were not describing different aspects of the same reality. They were asserting things that cannot both be true in the same sense. The universe either has a creator or it does not. The individual self either is ultimately real or it is not. Grace either is or is not the only available means of salvation. These are not questions of perspective. They are questions about what is actually the case.
Anekantavada invites humility about the limits of any single view, and this is a genuine contribution. But it cannot convert a genuine logical contradiction into a difference of emphasis. At some point, "from one perspective there is a creator and from another there is not" stops being a model of tolerance and starts being a failure of intellectual seriousness.

## VI. The Possibility of Levels

A more sophisticated response introduces the idea of levels of description. You say: the self, in one sense, exists — it acts, accumulates karma, submits, prays, makes moral choices. At a deeper level, the self is revealed to be a construction. At another level still, the relationship between the human being and the divine is mediated through grace, through specific historical events, through forms and sacraments. The contradictions are not denied but stratified: each tradition is taken to be operating at a different depth, addressing a different dimension of the human situation.
This is more nuanced than simple translation, and it corresponds to something real in the way many traditions

understand their own teachings. Most traditions distinguish between exoteric and esoteric dimensions, between outer practice and inner realisation, between what beginners are taught and what becomes accessible to more advanced practitioners. The idea that a tradition might have multiple layers is not foreign to the traditions themselves.

But the move still generates its own difficulties. The most significant is that the ordering of levels is not neutral. To say that Advaita's non-dual insight is the "deeper" level at which the Islamic emphasis on a personal creator-God is a "preliminary" teaching is not a philosophically innocent observation. It is the assertion that one tradition's deepest claim is more fundamental than another's, which is precisely the kind of ranking the levels model is supposed to avoid. The same problem arises in reverse: if the Christian insistence on the necessity of grace is placed at the "deeper" level, then all paths that rely on individual effort are "relative" truths at best. Either way, someone's ultimate claim gets demoted. The language of levels can clarify the relationships between different kinds of claims. It cannot, on its own, resolve the question of which claims are correct.

## VII. The Refusal to Resolve

What I arrived at, after sitting with these problems through the remainder of that evening and the weeks that followed, was a different relationship to the contradiction than the one I had started with. I had entered the experiment expecting, or at least hoping, that the contradictions would eventually resolve

themselves — that sufficient understanding would reveal a level at which the disagreements were apparent rather than real. What I found instead was that the contradictions were, in important respects, real. Not every disagreement between traditions is a misunderstanding, and the ones that matter most are often the ones that cannot be dissolved without doing violence to one or more of the positions.

This is not a comfortable conclusion, and I want to be precise about what it does and does not establish. It does not establish that one tradition is correct and the rest mistaken. It does not establish that interfaith understanding is impossible or worthless. What it establishes is something more limited: that the question "what did Ramakrishna verify?" is genuinely difficult, and that any answer which reaches for easy resolution is probably avoiding the hard part.

There is, however, a different way of hearing the phrase "as many opinions, so many paths" than the one I had been working with. If the phrase is taken as a claim that all doctrinal positions across traditions are simultaneously and literally true, then the contradictions are fatal to it. But if it is understood differently — not as a claim about the equivalence of doctrines but as an empirical observation about transformation — then something more interesting becomes possible. Ramakrishna may not have been claiming that Islamic theology and Advaita Vedanta are saying the same thing at the propositional level. He may have been reporting something more specific: that the practices of each tradition, taken seriously and pursued with full sincerity, produce a

quality of encounter with something larger than the ordinary self that the practitioner, on emerging, recognises as having been real. The doctrines are the maps. The territory may be the same for different maps, while the maps themselves remain genuinely, irreducibly different.

This thought was not yet fully formed. It would need more examination, and the next chapters return to it. What I had, walking out of the chaplaincy that evening, was not a resolution but a distinction — between the level of doctrine, where the contradictions are real and cannot be wished away, and the level of practice and transformation, where the question is still open.

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# Chapter Twelve

## *The Limits of Tolerance*

> *There is a point at which generosity becomes evasion, and the refusal to judge becomes a way of avoiding the demands that genuine encounter makes.*

### I. The Easy Word

Tolerance is a comfortable virtue in interfaith settings because it requires almost nothing. You do not have to revise your beliefs, defend them rigorously, or examine them too closely. You have only to allow that others hold theirs. In the early part of the experiment, this disposition seemed not just adequate but genuinely respectful — a way of honouring the integrity of traditions different from my own without presuming to evaluate them from outside. The interfaith dinners, the visits, the study circles all operated within this understanding, and it worked reasonably well as long as the differences stayed abstract.

What tolerance cannot survive, I began to discover, is specificity. The more I learned about any given tradition on its own terms, rather than in the sanitised version that traditions sometimes present to outsiders, the harder it became to maintain the relaxed goodwill that tolerance implies. The traditions make claims that are, if you take them seriously,

demanding and particular. They do not all point in the same direction. And when their demands touched things that I considered central — not peripheral customs or aesthetic preferences, but questions about human dignity, equality, and the nature of a well-lived life — tolerance either had to be redefined or acknowledged as insufficient.

## II. The Moment of Friction

The clearest instance of this occurred at one of the interfaith banquets, where the discussion turned, as it often does in pluralistic settings, to sexuality. The Muslim speaker, measured and thoughtful, explained the position of the tradition with care. Homosexual acts are not permitted. This is not, he was at pains to say, a matter of personal animosity toward any individual. It is a matter of law, derived from scripture and interpreted within a long and detailed tradition of jurisprudence. The person is to be treated with full human dignity. The act is not to be sanctioned. He said this without aggression, and I believed his account of his own motivations. The room adjusted itself to receive this in the spirit of tolerance. I found I could not fully make the same adjustment. The resistance was not purely emotional, though it had an emotional component. It was ethical. Within the framework I had absorbed through my upbringing and through the culture I inhabited, something important was at stake in how we understand the validity of human relationships and the authority of individuals over their own intimate lives. The Muslim speaker's position, I could see, was internally coherent.

It followed from premises that were themselves part of a carefully elaborated whole. Understanding the coherence of the position did not produce agreement with it, and the tolerance-as-suspension-of-judgment mode gave me no language for that distinction.

The difficulty with tolerance, as it functions in most interfaith settings, is that it is symmetrical. It applies as readily to positions I find reasonable as to positions I find harmful. If I extend tolerance to the claim that God is one, I am also extending it, by the same logic, to claims about which human relationships are permissible. There is no principled way, within a purely tolerant framework, to say that the first is different in kind from the second. But there is something important about the second kind of claim that is not captured by describing it as a cultural or theological difference deserving respect. At some point, tolerance reaches a boundary beyond which it would require me to treat as equally valid a position that I believe causes genuine harm to real people. I am not willing to do that, and the refusal is itself a kind of claim — the claim that tolerance has limits.

## III. The Gentle Boundary Within Every Tradition

A quieter version of the same problem had appeared earlier, in the Baha'i setting. The Baha'i faith presents an extraordinarily generous face to the world of interfaith encounter. Its theology of progressive revelation holds that all the major prophets — Abraham, Moses, Krishna, Zoroaster, Buddha, Jesus, Muhammad, and finally Baha'u'llah — are authentic

manifestations of the same divine will, suited to the age and conditions in which they appeared. The diversity of religions is not a problem to be solved but a sign of the richness of divine communication. All previous paths were valid. All entrances to the temple are equally open.

And yet the Baha'i faith also has specific laws, a fixed direction of prayer, an organised structure of authority in the Universal House of Justice, and a clear boundary: no new prophet will come for at least a thousand years, and Baha'u'llah's revelation is definitive for this age. You can approach from any direction, but inside, the space is defined. The universal language of openness coexists with a quite specific set of commitments and exclusions. This is not hypocrisy — it is simply the necessary structure of any tradition that takes itself seriously. Every tradition, however open it appears from the outside, has a point at which it says: this is what we believe, and not something else.

What this observation establishes is that tolerance, properly understood, is not the absence of boundaries. It is the recognition that all serious traditions have boundaries, that these boundaries are in genuine tension with each other, and that living with that tension is more intellectually honest than pretending it does not exist. The question is not whether to have standards but how to hold them — with sufficient conviction to mean something and sufficient humility to remain genuinely open to learning from traditions different from one's own.

## IV. The Pressure to Harmonise

There is, in pluralistic environments, a subtle but persistent pressure toward harmonisation. It comes from a genuinely good place — the desire to avoid conflict, the recognition that the people across the table are more than the positions they represent, the practical need to maintain relationships in a world where diversity is the norm. And it produces a characteristic mode of speech: “at the end of the day, we all believe in the same thing,” “it’s just different ways of saying the same truth,” “we all want peace and love and kindness.” These statements are comforting. They are also, in the precise sense, insufficiently true.

They are insufficiently true because, while they are accurate at a level so general as to be nearly tautological — yes, most traditions value something like compassion — they do not engage with the specific and consequential ways in which traditions differ about what compassion requires. The Islam that asks for submission to divine law and the Jainism that asks for radical non-violence and the Christianity that asks for trust in a specific divine person are not merely different cultural phrasings of a universal ethical intuition. They produce different kinds of people, organised around different priorities, making different choices about how to live. To say they are all saying the same thing is to miss what matters most about each of them.

More importantly, the pressure to harmonise tends to flow in one direction. It is rarely a genuine synthesis. More often, it is the imposition of one tradition’s framework — usually a

somewhat diluted version of the tradition that happens to dominate the cultural setting in which the conversation is taking place — on all the others. In a Western liberal context, this often means reducing all traditions to variations on a broadly Protestant conception of religion as a private spiritual experience that supports universal ethical values. Traditions whose claims are more specific, more demanding, or more incompatible with that framework are quietly encouraged to present themselves in its terms. This is not understanding. It is assimilation.

## V. The Risk of Detachment

One response to the discomfort of genuine difference is to become a careful observer rather than a participant — to appreciate the internal logic of each tradition from a position of informed distance, taking what resonates, leaving what does not, maintaining the freedom of someone who is not fully inside any single framework. I found myself occupying this position at various points, and I want to be honest about its appeal. It preserves intellectual freedom. It allows for genuine appreciation of multiple traditions without the friction that comes from being fully embedded in one. It feels, from inside, like openness.

But it also has a cost that I came to take more seriously. The traditions I was engaging with were not, primarily, objects for aesthetic or intellectual appreciation. They were paths designed to transform the person who follows them. They require something from the people inside them: submission,

surrender, ethical transformation, trust. A person who stands at the edge of each tradition, appreciating its beauty and noting its logic, but never allowing it to make its full demand, has understood something about the tradition but has also, in a crucial sense, declined what the tradition was actually offering. The understanding, however sophisticated, remains the understanding of someone who has looked through the window rather than entered the room.

There is also something intellectually uncomfortable about the detached position that I did not fully recognise at the time. The stance of appreciating all traditions equally from outside any of them is not, in fact, a neutral position. It is itself a position, with its own commitments and exclusions. It tends to value pluralism and individual autonomy and the suspension of strong commitment, which are not universal values. They are the values of a particular historical moment in a particular cultural setting. The person who claims to stand nowhere and appreciate everywhere is standing somewhere very specific, and that location shapes what they can see.

## VI. Tolerance and Truth

The distinction that eventually clarified itself was between tolerance as a political disposition and tolerance as an epistemic one. As a political disposition, tolerance is genuinely important and largely defensible. A pluralistic society requires, as a condition of peaceful coexistence, that individuals and communities be permitted to hold and practice their convictions without interference, provided they do not harm

others. This is a procedural commitment, not a philosophical one. It says nothing about which beliefs are true, only about which forms of coercion are legitimate.

As an epistemic disposition — as a claim about the relationship between competing truth claims — tolerance is far less stable. The idea that all sincere beliefs deserve equal respect as accounts of reality is, if pushed, incoherent. Beliefs can be sincerely held and still be mistaken, internally inconsistent, or harmful in their consequences. Respect for the person who holds a belief does not require treating the belief itself as immune from evaluation. And the evaluation of beliefs, honestly conducted, sometimes leads to the conclusion that they are wrong — not merely different, not merely culturally local, but mistaken about something that matters.

This is not an argument for disrespect. It is an argument for taking traditions seriously enough to engage with their claims rather than merely celebrating their existence. The most respectful engagement with a tradition is one that treats it as making real claims about reality, then examines those claims with the same rigour one would apply to any claim. That examination sometimes produces agreement, sometimes disagreement, and sometimes the recognition that the question is harder than either side had appreciated. What it does not produce, in the honest version, is the comfortable conclusion that everyone is right in their own way and the disagreements are superficial.

## VII. What Remains After the Limit

The experiment did not end when tolerance reached its limit. What changed was the frame within which I was conducting it. The early, tolerant mode had the advantage of keeping all doors open simultaneously, but it did so by not pressing too hard on any of them. The later mode, shaped by the recognition that the traditions genuinely disagree and that the disagreements matter, required a different kind of engagement: more precise, more willing to sit with discomfort, more honest about the possibility of being wrong.

What I found, in this later mode, was not that the traditions became less interesting. They became more so, because the specificity that makes them genuinely different from each other is also the specificity that makes each of them capable of doing something that a vague, harmonised spirituality cannot. A tradition that makes a specific claim about reality, that asks for a specific form of commitment, that shapes a specific kind of person, is offering something real. The price of that reality is the exclusion of other realities. You cannot have everything simultaneously. The question the experiment eventually forced was not whether to choose, but what choosing would actually mean.

The limit of tolerance is not a failure of the interfaith project. It is the point at which interfaith encounter becomes genuinely serious — where the differences are engaged as differences rather than managed as variations, and where the question of truth, rather than being bracketed in the interest of good feeling, is allowed to do its proper work. That is a harder and more uncomfortable place to stand. It is also, I came to think,

the place from which anything worth calling understanding can actually begin.

# Chapter Thirteen

## *The Ego of the Seeker*

> *There is a way of searching that is structured so as never to risk being found. The seeker who moves perpetually between traditions, collecting impressions and preserving the freedom to leave, has made a choice that the traditions themselves recognise as the hardest to undo.*

### I. The Pattern

For several years, my life had a particular rhythm. A temple one week, a mosque the next. A study circle on a Wednesday evening, a satsang on a Sunday afternoon. A church service, a Quaker meeting, a Jain meditation session, a living room where someone read from a book that had, for them, become the centre of everything. I moved through these spaces with genuine attention, sometimes with a notebook, more often with the kind of mental alertness that comes from being in a situation you do not quite understand and are trying to. I learned the vocabularies, the gestures, the protocols. I was welcomed, almost everywhere, with a generosity I did not always feel I had earned.

What I notice, looking back, is a pattern that was present throughout but that I did not clearly see until the experiment

was well advanced. In each setting, I was genuinely present. I was not pretending to be moved when I was not. But I was also, always, preserving a position from which I could leave. I did not submit, not fully. I did not surrender. I did not commit. I engaged with each tradition to the point of real understanding, and then I stepped back. The exit was always available, always near, and it was never quite examined for what it was.

## II. What Each Tradition Required

Each tradition I encountered was not, at its core, asking for understanding. It was asking for something more specific and more demanding. Islam, in its literal meaning and in the shape of the life it asks for, requires submission — not the intellectual acceptance of a set of propositions but the reorganisation of the entire day, the entire year, the entire moral life around a relationship with the divine that has priority over everything else. The structure of salat, five times daily, is not an optional supplement to ordinary life. It is its orientation.

The bhakti traditions I encountered through ISKCON asked for surrender of a different texture but similar totality: the cultivation of a devotional relationship that becomes, over time, the ground from which everything else grows. The nine forms of devotional service — hearing, chanting, remembering, serving the Lord's feet, worshipping, praying, becoming a servant, becoming a friend, offering oneself — are not a catalogue of options. They are the progressive deepening of a single orientation. A person who finds some of them appealing

and leaves the others is not practicing bhakti. They are appreciating it.

Jainism asked for an ethical seriousness that is, if genuinely followed, total. Non-violence carried to its logical conclusion does not mean being generally kind. It means reorganising one's life — diet, occupation, daily movement, speech, even thought — around the principle that every living being has the same kind of inner life one has oneself, and therefore the same claim on one's moral attention. The great Jain monk Bahubali did not stand motionless while vines climbed his legs because he was illustrating a philosophical point. He was demonstrating what the tradition actually requires.

Christianity, as I encountered it across the range from Jesuit retreat to Pentecostal revival meeting, asked for trust in a specific person, which is different in structure from trust in a principle or a set of practices. You cannot trust Christ in the way the tradition asks while simultaneously treating that trust as one option among several to be held in reserve. The Jesuit retreat director who told me to stay with the feeling of warmth and not listen to the small voice of scepticism was not asking for intellectual assent. He was asking for a movement of the will toward something that the will cannot entirely verify in advance. That movement, or something like it, is what the tradition means by faith, and it is not compatible with the stance of the observer who has reserved the right to withdraw.

## III. The Spiritual Collector

Chogyam Trungpa, the Tibetan Buddhist teacher who spent the last decades of his life teaching in the West, identified what he called spiritual materialism as the characteristic obstacle of the modern spiritual seeker. The concept is precise and uncomfortable enough that I want to give it its full weight rather than summarise it quickly. The idea is that the ego — the sense of being a fixed, separate self that requires maintenance and enhancement — is not dissolved by spiritual practice as a matter of course. It is, rather, extraordinarily resourceful at colonising it. The ego uses the spiritual path for the same purposes it uses everything else: to build a more impressive, more secure, more credentialled version of itself.

The person who has attended Sufi ceremonies and Zen retreats and Vipassana courses and bhakti festivals and interfaith conferences, and who speaks knowledgeably about the phenomenology of each, has not necessarily moved closer to the transformation that any of these traditions is oriented toward. They may have moved further away from it, because the collection itself — and the self that curates and presents the collection — has become more elaborate and more defended. Each genuine encounter with a tradition, each moment of real stillness or presence or clarity, is absorbed by the ego and converted into an acquisition. The pilgrim who accumulates holy sites is not thereby made holy. The seeker who accumulates traditions is not thereby liberated from the self that is doing the seeking.

Trungpa's diagnosis does not rest on any claim about the inauthenticity of the individual experiences. The moments of

genuine contact were real. The people encountered were sincere. The insights gained were not invented. The point is more structural: that genuine experience, if it is not followed by the transformation the tradition actually requires, can be absorbed back into the ego's project of self-enhancement without leaving a permanent mark. You can be genuinely moved by the Jain teaching on non-violence and then, having been moved, return to your ordinary life with a richer inner catalogue. The movement was real. The ego remained.

## IV. The Specific Failure

I want to sit with this charge rather than deflect it. The question is whether my engagement with the traditions over the years of the experiment constitutes spiritual materialism in Trungpa's sense. I think the honest answer is: partially, and significantly.

The aspect that troubles me most is not the breadth of the exploration but what happened at the boundary of each tradition. In every case, there was a point at which the tradition asked for something I was not prepared to give. Not a small thing, not a peripheral custom, but the specific form of commitment that the tradition considers central to its practice. And in every case, I found a way to engage with the tradition that stopped just short of that point. I chanted without surrendering. I prayed without submitting. I meditated without allowing the dissolution that the tradition was pointing toward. I participated in the forms while maintaining an

implicit condition: I will do this, for now, and I will observe what happens, and then I will see.

This condition is lethal to the kind of transformation the traditions describe. Every serious practice tradition, across the full range of what I encountered, holds that the essential movement cannot happen as long as the practitioner is simultaneously watching themselves practice. The Zen instruction to "just sit" is precisely an instruction to stop observing the sitting. The Sufi's fana, the dissolution of the self in the divine, cannot occur as a managed experiment. The Quaker instruction to wait in silence without an agenda is undermined by sitting in silence with a quiet hypothesis to test. I was, in every case, running an experiment on a process that cannot be run as an experiment without changing it into something else.

## V. Ramakrishna's Method Reconsidered

Returning, again, to Ramakrishna, the difference in method is now clearer than it was at the beginning. He did not approach the traditions as objects of study. He entered them. The accounts we have — mediated through the Gospel compiled by Mahendranath Gupta and through later biographical sources — describe a man who, when he practiced Islam, did not simultaneously hold his devotion to Kali as a parallel framework. He dressed in Muslim clothing, he ate food prepared in the Muslim manner, he thought of Muhammad, he prayed in the Muslim style, and he allowed the entire structure of his ordinary perception to be reorganised by that practice.

When he practiced Christianity, he sat with Christian devotees and meditated on the figure of Christ to the exclusion, for that period, of other forms.

This is not the behaviour of a comparative religionist. It is the behaviour of someone who has placed himself completely at the disposal of the tradition he is entering, which means allowing it to do to him what it does to the people who live inside it. The verification he arrived at — that the same luminous presence appeared at the end of each path — was the result of having actually walked each path, not of having observed it from a sympathetic distance. The conclusion, "as many opinions, so many paths," is only available to someone who has gone far enough down multiple paths to speak from experience about what they encounter. My version of the experiment gave me the beginning of several paths. It did not give me far enough along any of them to speak with the same authority.

The difference may not be one of degree alone. It may be structural. The kind of seeker Ramakrishna was — someone in whom the longing for the divine was so overwhelming that it consumed every other concern, who wept before the image of Kali with the desperation of a person drowning, for whom the question of whether God was real was not a philosophical inquiry but the single most urgent question of his life — that kind of seeker cannot easily preserve the observer's position. The longing itself, at sufficient intensity, drives out the detachment. I had not experienced longing of that intensity. I

am not sure that is a failure of will. It may simply be a description of where I was.

## VI. The Possibility of Another Kind of Experiment

The recognition of what the experiment lacked does not necessarily invalidate what it found. The experiences were real. The questions they generated were genuine. The understanding of each tradition, however incomplete, was not nothing. But it does change the framing of what those experiences can claim to establish.

What I can honestly report is not what a person discovers at the far end of a tradition, having gone far enough to lose themselves in it. That is Ramakrishna's testimony, and I have no grounds to replicate or refute it from where I have stood. What I can report is something more modest: what the traditions look like from the threshold, when you have gone far enough to understand their internal logic and far enough to feel the pull of what they are asking, but not so far that you have allowed them to reorganise you at the level they consider essential.

From that position, the traditions do not look like the same thing expressed in different vocabularies. They look like genuinely different things, oriented toward genuinely different forms of human transformation, making genuinely incompatible claims about reality, and each capable, in its own right, of something that the detached observer cannot fully access. The Ramakrishna question — whether all paths lead to the same place — remains genuinely open. It cannot be settled

from the threshold. It requires someone willing to do what Ramakrishna did, which is to stop being a seeker and become, for the duration of each path, a practitioner. I was, throughout, a seeker. That is a real limitation, and it is the one the ego of the seeker is most invested in not seeing.

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# Chapter Fourteen

## *The Failure of the Experiment*

> *Not all experiments fail loudly. Some fail by never quite meeting their own conditions. The question is whether, having recognised this, anything of value remains.*

### I. What Was Claimed

The experiment had a specific premise. Sri Ramakrishna practiced multiple traditions sequentially, entering each with full commitment, and reported arriving at the same luminous encounter in each. He drew from this the conclusion expressed in the Bengali phrase joto mot, toto path: as many opinions, so many paths. The claim, as I understood it, was empirical rather than merely philosophical. He was not arguing from analogy or from the internal logic of any single tradition that the others must lead to the same place. He was reporting what happened when he actually went there. The premise of my experiment was that something like this — not the same intensity, not the same depth, but the same basic orientation — could be attempted and that its results would be informative.

### II. Where It Fell Short

The three preceding chapters have, I think, established the ways in which the experiment did not meet its own conditions.

The method was not what Ramakrishna's method was. Where he entered, I observed. Where he allowed each tradition to reorganise his perception completely, I engaged from a position of reflective distance that I never fully surrendered. Where he practiced each path until he arrived at its inner threshold, I spent time at the entrance of many paths without going deep enough into any to reach the point where the practice does its essential work. The experiment, honestly assessed, was less a replication of Ramakrishna's inquiry and more a sustained engagement with the surfaces of multiple traditions by someone who was genuinely interested but not genuinely committed.

There is also a structural difference between his situation and mine that cannot be attributed simply to failures of will. He lived in a context in which total immersion was not only possible but culturally supported. The Dakshineswar Kali temple provided a physical and social location from which the experiments could be launched and to which he could return. He had teachers within each tradition who guided the practice from inside their own deep familiarity with it. He had, as far as we can tell from the accounts, an intensity of longing for the divine that removed the question of whether to practice from the ordinary category of choices. The contemporary urban seeker, managing a professional life, moving between traditions that are themselves not fully integrated into the social fabric of the city, practising under the condition of simultaneous exposure to many competing frameworks, is working in a very different set of constraints. This does not

excuse the limitation. But it is part of an honest description of it.

### III. What Was Found Instead

What I found, in place of the verification the experiment was designed to produce, was something with its own value, even if it is not what was sought. The encounters were real, and some of what they left is worth describing precisely.

The first is negative: the traditions do not converge at the level of doctrine. The contradictions mapped in Chapter Eleven are genuine, and they matter. The idea that all religions are different languages for the same thing, comforting as it is, does not survive close engagement with what the traditions actually claim. The Jain universe without a creator is not the same universe as the Islamic one sustained by divine will, and the difference is not merely verbal. A spirituality that collapses this distinction has not risen above the traditions. It has misunderstood them.

The second finding is more positive, and it concerns the level of practice rather than doctrine. Each tradition I encountered was capable, in its own way, of producing states of attention and presence that were qualitatively different from ordinary experience. The stillness before Bahubali, the presence at Nizamuddin, the warmth in the church hall, the silence of the Quaker meeting — these were not identical experiences, and they were not produced by identical means, but they shared a quality of increased reality, of heightened attention, of contact with something that felt more solid than the ordinary flow of

mental life. Whether these experiences constitute encounters with the same ultimate reality is a question I cannot answer. But the question is genuine, which is itself a finding of the experiment: the traditions are doing something real, and the something is worth continued inquiry.

The third finding is about the relationship between particularity and universality, which was clarified most sharply by the encounters with Sikhism and Judaism described in earlier chapters. The universal is not accessible by discarding the particular. The langar in the gurdwara is not simply an illustration of the abstract principle that everyone deserves to eat. It is a specific practice, rooted in a specific theology, that the abstract principle cannot replace. The Hanukkah candles placed by the door are not a universalised sentiment about the persistence of light. They are a specific testimony made by specific people on specific nights because their ancestors did the same. What the traditions carry into the world, they carry in containers that cannot be removed from the water without the water spilling. Ramakrishna's insight is not that the containers are irrelevant. It is that different containers, filled from the same source, carry the same thing — and that you have to look inside the containers, not merely admire them from outside, to find out whether this is true.

## IV. The Question of Ramakrishna's Claim

The failure of the experiment to replicate Ramakrishna's results does not refute his claim. It would be a mistake to treat it as though it did. There are several ways to account for the

discrepancy without concluding that what he reported was false.

One is the question of depth. The experiment did not go far enough into any tradition to reach the point at which the tradition's essential work occurs. If Ramakrishna is right that all paths lead to the same destination, then it follows that you have to go far enough along the path to find out. My experiment established that the early stages of multiple paths are different from each other. This is consistent with both his claim and its negation.

Another is the question of the observer. The Chapter on the ego of the seeker established that the experimental posture — the stance of the reflective observer who has reserved the right to withdraw — is precisely the posture that the traditions identify as the obstacle to their essential work. An experiment structured to prevent the dissolution of the self cannot test the claim that the self dissolves at the end of the path. The hypothesis and the method were in tension from the beginning.

A third is the possibility of what Chapter Eleven called a category distinction: that Ramakrishna's claim is not about doctrinal equivalence but about the quality of experience available to someone who pursues any of these paths with full sincerity. On this reading, the paths remain genuinely different — they require different things, produce different kinds of people, make incompatible claims about the structure of reality — and yet each of them, if followed to its inner depths, opens onto something that the practitioner, looking across at what

their counterpart in a different tradition has found, recognises as being of the same order. Not identical, but of the same kind: something that the word “God” or “liberation” or “non-dual awareness” is trying, in each tradition’s own vocabulary, to point at. This reading preserves the force of the intuition without collapsing the genuine differences.

## V. The Modern Condition

There is a further question worth addressing honestly: whether the experiment as described here is the only form the Ramakrishna inquiry can take in a contemporary context, or whether there are others that might be more adequate.

The form I chose — engagement with multiple traditions over a period of years, without full commitment to any — corresponds to a particular kind of modern religious life that is increasingly common. Many people today inhabit multiple traditions simultaneously, or move between them at different periods of their lives, or construct personal syntheses from elements of several. This is not unprecedented historically, but it is newly widespread, and it raises genuine questions about what spiritual formation means under these conditions. The question is not whether this kind of life is valid. It is what it can and cannot discover.

What it seems able to discover are the surfaces and the shallows: the ways in which traditions present themselves to outsiders, the experiences available at the threshold, the intellectual frameworks that make each tradition coherent from the outside. What it seems less able to discover is what

the traditions themselves identify as their deepest content, which in every case requires a form of commitment, surrender, or trust that the experimental posture resists. This is not a criticism of people who live religiously in the way I have described. It is an attempt to be precise about what this mode of engagement can and cannot honestly claim.

## VI. What the Failure Produced

The failure of the experiment to produce its intended result — the verification of Ramakrishna's claim through personal experience — produced something else instead. It produced, over time, a set of questions that are more precise than the one the experiment began with.

The original question was: do all paths lead to the same place? This is, as it stands, too coarse. It conflates the level of doctrine (where the paths genuinely differ and the differences matter) with the level of practice and transformation (where the question is still genuinely open). It does not distinguish between the experience available at the threshold of a tradition and the experience available to someone who has gone past the threshold. It does not address the question of what kind of self must be present for the encounter to occur, or the possibility that the encounter requires a self that has, at least partially, given up the observer's position.

The more precise questions that the experiment left behind are: What does each tradition actually do to the person who fully enters it, rather than merely observes it? Is there a form of comparison across traditions that does not require the

observer's stance, but is conducted from inside multiple practices rather than outside all of them? Is the quality of presence encountered in the deepest moments of different traditions recognisably similar, and if so, does that similarity constitute evidence for the kind of claim Ramakrishna was making, or is it better explained in other terms? These questions are, I think, more answerable than the original one, not because they are easier, but because they are more precisely formulated.

## VII. The Paths Remain

There is a passage in the Gospel of Sri Ramakrishna, reported by Mahendranath Gupta, in which Ramakrishna says: "The lake has several ghats. Hindus drink water at one ghat, Muslims at another, Christians at yet another. All drink the same water. So, too, the Lord has made different religions suited to different times, countries and people." The image is simple and memorable. It is also, in one important respect, inexact: you do not drink the lake from the bank. You have to go in.

The experiment I conducted was, in the end, an extended time spent at the various banks of a lake, tasting the water at each ghat, noting its character, comparing the quality at one edge with the quality at another. This is not nothing. You learn something real about a lake from its shores. But you do not learn what it is to be immersed in it, which is what the traditions, when they speak of liberation or salvation or enlightenment or union, are trying to describe.

The paths remain. They were there before the experiment began and they are there after it ended. The people who are genuinely inside them — who have submitted, surrendered, committed, or been graced into something they did not manage to engineer for themselves — are reporting something that my version of the experiment cannot evaluate from outside. What I can say, with confidence earned through the engagement of the preceding years, is that what they are reporting is not illusion. There is something happening in each of these traditions. Something that, at times and at the threshold, I felt, even if I did not fully enter into it.

Whether that something is the same thing in each case, I do not know. Ramakrishna knew, or at least reported knowing. The difference between us is not, I think, primarily a matter of intelligence or seriousness or philosophical sophistication. It is a matter of a specific kind of willingness — the willingness to allow the path to do its work without reserving the option of withdrawal. That willingness is either present or it is not. Whether it can be cultivated, and what it would take, and whether the cultivation itself is another form of the ego's project of self-improvement, are questions that the experiment has left me with, without having answered them.

The water in the lake is the same water. I have tasted it at several ghats. I have not yet gone in.

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